

SSCHA School Tutorials

Hands-on sessions on the Stochastic Self-Consistent Harmonic Approximation

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Chapter 1

Setup guide

The hands-on sessions of the 2026 SSCHA School will be run on a virtual machine, with the SSCHA software pre-installed. It is important that all the participants have the VM ready and working **before** the beginning of the school, as during the limited time available for the school we will not go through the software installation.

In the following we detail all the step required to be ready to run the tutorials and participate to the hands-on session

1.1 The virtual machine

To run the tutorials, we recommend using a custom version of the Quantum Mobile virtual machine. The download links for Intel or Apple Silicon chips are the following:

1. [Intel x86/AMD64](#)
2. [Apple Silicon/ARM64](#)

(A huge thanks to Marnik Bercx, Nicola Colonna and all the people involved from Quantum Mobile for building this version for the ICTP/MARVEL College: Materials simulations in the age of AI).

To start the virtual machine, you must import it inside Oracle VirtualBox.

NOTE: VirtualBox version 7.2 at least is required. The virtual machine will not work on old VirtualBox versions.

Run until the machine starts. Note that running the VM for the first time requires a lot of free space on the disc (up to about 30 GB).

1.2 Installing required force fields

Once inside the virtual machine, open a terminal. Every tutorial will be run inside the SSCHA conda environment. To access it use

```
1 conda activate sscha
```

This needs to be done every time you open a new terminal. A (**sscha**) text should appear at the beginning of the prompt line. Then install the force-fields required for running the tutorials:

```
1 pip install quippy-ase F3ToyModel
```

You are now ready for the hands-on sessions 1-4.

1.3 EPIq installation

Chapter 2

Hands-on Session 1 - First SSCHA Simulations: Free Energy and Structural Relaxations

In this hands-on session, we provide few simple examples of how to use the SSCHA code for its most basic calculations: free energy calculations and structural relaxations considering anharmonic effects. The example will be based on calculations performed using a GAP machine learning potential for the $Pm - 3m$ phase of $CsPbI_3$ perovskite structure.

The variational minimization of the free energy within the SSCHA requires several steps:

- Define a starting crystal structure with definite positions to start the minimization of the free energy assuming ionic wave functions are centered at these positions.
- Define starting auxiliary force constants in a supercell as starting force constants for the minimization of the free energy. Even if this is not necessary, usually harmonic force constants are a good starting point.
- Create random ionic positions in the chosen supercell based on the probability distribution function defined by the initial positions and force constants.
- Calculate Born-Oppenheimer (BO) total energies, BO atomic forces, and BO lattice stresses for all these configurations. This has to be done with an external code independent of the SSCHA. The theory level used for these calculations (DFT, Monte Carlo, Empirical Force Field, Machine Learning potential...) determined the theory level behind the SSCHA.
- Perform the minimization of the free energy, optimizing the atomic positions (centers of the SSCHA ionic wave functions) and auxiliary force constants.
- The minimization will stop if the minimum of the free energy is found within the determined threshold or if the calculation has gone out of the statistical save range.
- In the latter case, one should restart the calculation by creating a new set of configurations using as input the obtained positions and auxiliary force constants in the previous run. The process should be repeated until convergence is found.

In this tutorial we will show how to perform such calculations, starting from the most basic usage of the code to more advanced automatic type of calculations.

2.1 A standard manual calculation with an external force engine

The starting ionic (centroid) positions and force constants are read by the SSCHA from Quantum Espresso dynamical matrix files. We provide some harmonic calculations for $CsPbI_3$ in the folder `sscha_school_2026/``Materials/CsPbI3_cubic_harmonic_*`. In these files the structure of the crystal is given, and each of the files

corresponds to the force constants matrix obtained in reciprocal space for all the irreducible q points in a $2 \times 2 \times 2$ grid. In this case there are 4 different q points in the irreducible grid. This is enough to create the force constants in a commensurate $2 \times 2 \times 2$ supercell.

In this first example we will do all the steps of the SSCHA minimization separately, one by one. In the first step we will read the input positions and force constants from the harmonic dynamical matrices and create 50 random configurations based on probability distribution functions defined by these positions and force constants. This is done by the script `sscha_school_2026/Tutorials/01-Free_Energy_Structural_Relaxations/create_configurations.py`, which is copied here:

```

1  # Import cellconstructor needed things
2  import cellconstructor as CC
3  import cellconstructor.Phonons
4
5  # Import the modules to run the sscha
6  import sscha, sscha.Ensemble, sscha.SchaMinimizer
7  import sscha.Relax, sscha.Utilities
8
9  #-----
10 # We set up the parameters for the calculation
11
12 # The temperature for the calculation in K
13 TEMPERATURE = 450
14
15 # We tell the system that we are going to create the configurations
16 # of the first population. This is just used for labeling purposes.
17 POPULATION = 1
18
19 # We determine the number of configurations that we will generate
20 # for this population
21 N_RANDOM = 50
22
23 # We tell where the starting dynamical matrices in reciprocal space are
24 # for the q points commensurate with the supercell we want to use for
25 # the calculation. These dynamical matrices should be in Quantum Espresso
26 # format.
27 START_DYN = "../Materials/CsPbI3_cubic_harmonic_"
28 # In case we want to create the configurations from the result of a previous
29 # minimization we can use this starting dynamical matrices
30 #START_DYN = namefile='dyn_end_population'+str(POPULATION-1)+'_'
31 #
32 # We indicate how many irreducible q points are there for the q points in the grid.
33 NQIRR = 4
34 #-----
35
36 # Step 1: load the harmonic dynamical matrices and the crystal structure
37
38 dyn = CC.Phonons.Phonons(START_DYN, NQIRR) # Load them and read the structure
39 dyn.ForcePositiveDefinite()                # Force positive phonons in case there are
40                                           # imaginary phonon frequencies
41 dyn.Symmetrize()                            # Impose symmetries and the acoustic sum
42                                           # rule
43
44 # Step 2: create the ensemble, the configurations for which we have to calculate the
45 # forces, energies and stresses
46
47 ensemble = sscha.Ensemble.Ensemble(dyn, TEMPERATURE)
48 ensemble.generate(N_RANDOM)

```

```

47
48 # Step 3: We save the ensemble
49
50 namefile='population'+str(POPULATION)+'_ensemble' # Name of the folder to store the
    ensemble
51 ensemble.save(namefile, POPULATION)

```

After running this python script as

```

1 python create_configurations.py

```

we will obtain a folder with the name `population1_ensemble`, where files `u_population1*.dat` and `scf_population1*.dat` are stored. In the former how much atom is displaced from the starting positions is given in Bohr units and in the latter positions and lattice vectors in the supercell with the corresponding displacement ready to be used in DFT calculations are given. This run will also produce `dyn_start_population1*` dynamical matrices, which are those used to create the configurations, basically the input ones with positive frequencies and ASR forced.

The next step is to calculate the BO total energies, BO atomic forces and BO stresses for all these configurations. These have to be stored in the folder `population1_ensemble` with names `energies_supercell_population1.dat`, where all energies calculated in the supercell in Ry are concatenated; `forces_population1*.dat`, where in each file the forces of the atoms are given in Ry/Bohr (one line per atom with Cartesian coordinates in the same line); and `pressure_population1*.dat`, where in each file the 3×3 stress tensor is given in Ry/Bohr³. These calculations can be done externally with any code and prepare these files a posteriori.

In this case we perform the calculations with the GAP machine learning potential given in `sscha_school_2026/Materials/`. This is the python script `sscha_school_2026/Tutorials/01-Free_Energy_Structural_Relaxations/run_force_energy_engine.py` that does that:

```

1 # Import cellconstructor needed things
2 import cellconstructor as CC
3 import cellconstructor.Phonons
4
5 # Import the modules to run the sscha
6 import sscha, sscha.Ensemble, sscha.SchaMinimizer
7 import sscha.Relax, sscha.Utilities
8
9 # Import the module to be able to run the ML potential
10 from quippy.potential import Potential
11
12 # Import ASE for reading data
13 import ase
14
15 #-----
16 # We set up the parameters for the calculation
17
18 # The temperature for the calculation in K
19 TEMPERATURE = 450
20
21 # We tell the system that we are going to create the configurations
22 # of the first population. This is just used for labeling purposes.
23 POPULATION = 1
24
25 # We determine the number of configurations that we will generate
26 # for this population
27 N_RANDOM = 50
28
29 # We define the dynamical matrices that generated the ensemble and the folder where
30 # the ensemble is stored

```



```

31 START_DYN = 'dyn_start_population'+str(POPULATION)+'_'
32 folder_with_ensemble = 'population'+str(POPULATION)+'_ensemble'
33 NQIRR = 4
34
35 # We determine the potential to be used
36 POTENTIAL = '../Materials/GAP_1.xml'
37 calc = Potential("IP GAP", param_filename=POTENTIAL)
38
39 #-----
40
41 # We define numbers for the change of units between ASE and SSCHA
42 RyToEv = 13.605693
43 BohrToAngstrom = 0.529177
44
45 # We perform the calculations and write the results in the appropriate files with the
  appropriate units
46 energy_file=str(folder_with_ensemble)+'/energies_supercell_population'+str(POPULATION)+
  '.dat'
47 with open(energy_file, "w") as f_energy:
48
49     struct = CC.Structure.Structure()
50     for i in range(N_RANDOM):
51         namefile=str(folder_with_ensemble)+'/scf_population'+str(POPULATION)+'_'+str(i
          +1)+'.dat'
52         struct.read_scf(namefile)
53         ase_struct = struct.get_ase_atoms()
54         ase_struct.set_calculator(calc)
55         energy = ase_struct.get_potential_energy()
56         forces = ase_struct.get_forces()
57         stress = ase_struct.get_stress()
58
59         # --- Write energy in Ry ---
60         f_energy.write(f"{energy/RyToEv:.10f}\n")
61
62         # --- Write forces file in Ry/Bohr ---
63         forces_file = str(folder_with_ensemble)+'/forces_population'+str(POPULATION)+'_'
          +str(i+1)+'.dat'
64         with open(forces_file, "w") as f_forces:
65             for f in forces:
66                 f_forces.write(f"{f[0]* (BohrToAngstrom / RyToEv):.10f} {f[1]* (
                  BohrToAngstrom / RyToEv):.10f} {f[2]* (BohrToAngstrom / RyToEv):.10
                  f}\n")
67
68         # --- Write stress file in Ry/Bohr3 ---
69         stress_file = str(folder_with_ensemble)+'/pressure_population'+str(POPULATION)+
          '_'+str(i+1)+'.dat'
70         with open(stress_file, "w") as f_stress:
71             # ASE gives 6 components: xx yy zz yz xz xy
72             f_stress.write(f"{stress[0]* (BohrToAngstrom**3 / RyToEv)} {stress[5]* (
                  BohrToAngstrom**3 / RyToEv)} {stress[4]* (BohrToAngstrom**3 / RyToEv)}\n")
73             f_stress.write(f"{stress[5]* (BohrToAngstrom**3 / RyToEv)} {stress[1]* (
                  BohrToAngstrom**3 / RyToEv)} {stress[3]* (BohrToAngstrom**3 / RyToEv)}\n")
74             f_stress.write(f"{stress[4]* (BohrToAngstrom**3 / RyToEv)} {stress[3]* (
                  BohrToAngstrom**3 / RyToEv)} {stress[2]* (BohrToAngstrom**3 / RyToEv)}\n")

```

After running this python script as

```
python run_force_energy_engine.py
```

in the `population1_ensemble` folder we will obtain all the energies, forces and stresses that the SSCHA needs for the minimization. If an external code is done for this part, one should prepare these files externally.

With all these files ready, the variational minimization is ready to be done. We will do that with the script `sscha_school_2026/Tutorials/01-Free_Energy_Structural_Relaxations/minimize.py`:

```
1 from __future__ import print_function
2 from __future__ import division
3 import sys,os
4
5 import warnings
6
7 # Import cellconstructor needed things
8 import cellconstructor as CC
9 import cellconstructor.Phonons
10
11 # Import the modules to run the sscha
12 import sscha, sscha.Ensemble, sscha.SchaMinimizer
13 import sscha.Relax, sscha.Utilities
14
15 # Import the module to be able to run the ML potential
16 from quippy.potential import Potential
17
18 # Import ASE for reading data
19 import ase
20
21 # Import matplotlib and numpy
22 import matplotlib
23 import matplotlib.pyplot as plt
24 from matplotlib import colors as mcolors
25 from matplotlib import cm
26 import numpy as np
27
28 # NumPy moved ComplexWarning in newer versions. This block keeps the script
29 # compatible with both older and newer NumPy releases.
30 try:
31     ComplexWarning = np.exceptions.ComplexWarning
32 except AttributeError:
33     ComplexWarning = np.ComplexWarning
34
35 warnings.filterwarnings("ignore", category=ComplexWarning)
36
37 #-----
38 # We set up the parameters for the calculation
39
40 # The temperature for the calculation in K
41 TEMPERATURE = 450
42
43 # We tell the system that we are going to create the configurations
44 # of the first population. This is just used for labeling purposes.
45 POPULATION = 1
46
47 # We determine the number of configurations that we will generate
48 # for this population
49 N_RANDOM = 50
50
51 # We define the dynamical matrices that generated the ensemble and the folder where
```

```

52 # the ensemble is stored
53 START_DYN = 'dyn_start_population'+str(POPULATION)+'_'
54 folder_with_ensemble = 'population'+str(POPULATION)+'_ensemble'
55 NQIRR = 4
56 dyn = CC.Phonons.Phonons(START_DYN, NQIRR)
57
58 # We determine the potential to be used
59 POTENTIAL = '../Materials/GAP_1.xml'
60 calc = Potential("IP GAP", param_filename=POTENTIAL)
61
62 # We load the ensemble and read the results of the configurations
63 ensemble = sscha.Ensemble.Ensemble(dyn, TEMPERATURE)
64 ensemble.load(folder_with_ensemble, population = POPULATION, N = N_RANDOM)
65 ensemble.has_stress = True
66
67 # Define the minimization
68
69 minimizer = sscha.SchaMinimizer.SSCHA_Minimizer(ensemble)
70
71 # Define the steps for the centroids and the force constants
72
73 minimizer.min_step_dyn = 0.005           # The minimization step on the dynamical matrix
74 minimizer.min_step_struc = 0.05          # The minimization step on the structure
75 minimizer.kong_liu_ratio = 0.2           # The parameter that estimates whether the
76     ensemble is still good
77 minimizer.meaningful_factor = 0.000001 # How much small the gradient should be before I
78     stop?
79
80 # Let's start the minimization
81
82 minimizer.init()
83 minimizer.run()
84
85 # Save the minimization details
86 ioinfo = sscha.Utilities.IOInfo()
87 ioinfo.SetupSaving("minim_{}".format(POPULATION))
88
89 minimizer.run(custom_function_post = ioinfo.CFP_SaveAll)
90 minimizer.finalize()
91 namefile='dyn_end_population'+str(POPULATION)+'_'
92 minimizer.dyn.save_qe(namefile)

```

This script can be run as

```

1 python minimize.py > population1.log

```

The evolution of the minimization can be seen in the `population1.log` file, where in the end we will see why the minimization stopped, the obtained free energy in the unit cell, the gradients of the free energy, effective Kong-Liu sampling, the force on the centroids, and the stress tensor. The minimization probably stopped because the statistical sampling worsened beyond the input criteria. The obtained auxiliary dynamical matrices and positions are stored in the files `dyn_end_population1_*`.

Exercise:

Considering that the minimization stopped because it got out of the statistical range, perform a new minimization step (population = 2) starting from the output of the first minimization.

2.2 An automatic calculation for fixed lattice parameters

The manual calculations explained before can be easy if not many populations are needed to converge the result and we have no option but performing the energy-force calculations externally, for instance in a cluster. However, with force fields or Machine Learning potentials the SSCHA can make all the process above automatically, population after population, in one single script. This can be done by making use of the relax feature of the SSCHA. An example can be done with the following script `sscha_school_2026/Tutorials/01-Free_Energy_Structural_Relaxations/sscha_relax.py`:

```
1 import cellconstructor as CC, cellconstructor.Phonons
2 import sscha, sscha.Ensemble, sscha.SchaMinimizer
3 import sscha.Relax
4
5 from quippy.potential import Potential
6
7 import sys, os
8
9 import ase
10 import numpy as np
11
12 import warnings
13
14 # NumPy moved ComplexWarning in newer versions. This block keeps the script
15 # compatible with both older and newer NumPy releases.
16 try:
17     ComplexWarning = np.exceptions.ComplexWarning
18 except AttributeError:
19     ComplexWarning = np.ComplexWarning
20
21 warnings.filterwarnings("ignore", category=ComplexWarning)
22
23 TEMPERATURE = 450 # K
24 NQIRR = 4
25 START_DYN = "../Materials/CsPbI3_cubic_harmonic_"
26 POTENTIAL = "../Materials/GAP_1.xml"
27 N_CONFIGS = 50
28
29
30 # Load the harmonic dynamical matrix
31 dyn = CC.Phonons.Phonons(START_DYN, NQIRR)
32
33 # Force positive phonons
34 dyn.ForcePositiveDefinite()
35
36 # Impose symmetries and ASR
37 dyn.Symmetrize()
38
39 # Load the interatomic Potential for CsPbI3
40 calc = Potential("IP GAP", param_filename=POTENTIAL)
41
42 # Run the sscha
43 ensemble = sscha.Ensemble.Ensemble(dyn, TEMPERATURE)
44 minimizer = sscha.SchaMinimizer.SSCHA_Minimizer(ensemble)
45 minimizer.meaningful_factor = 0.000001
46 minimizer.set_minimization_step(0.001)
47 minimizer.kong_liu_ratio = 0.2
48 relax = sscha.Relax.SSCHA(minimizer, calc, N_configs = N_CONFIGS)
49
50 # Setup to save the minimization details every good minimization step
```

```

51 # Allows to plot minimization results
52 ioinfo = sscha.Utilities.IOInfo()
53 ioinfo.SetupSaving("minimization_data")
54 relax.setup_custom_functions(custom_function_post = ioinfo.CFP_SaveAll)
55
56 relax.relax()
57
58 # Save the final ensemble
59 relax.minim.ensemble.save_bin("data", 1)
60 relax.minim.dyn.save_qe("sscha_auxiliary_dyn_")

```

This script can be run as:

```

1 python sscha_relax.py > sscha_relax.log

```

With this script the minimization continues until the gradients of the free energy become smaller than the input value, relative to the error. In this case, the final dynamical matrices are stored in `sscha_auxiliary_dyn_`. The evolution of the minimization can be visualized more clearly using the following command

```

1 sscha-plot-data minimization_data

```

by plotting the evolution of the minimization stored in the files `minimization_data.freqs` and `minimization_data.dat`. We should get something like:

Figure 1. Evolution of the free energy, gradients with respect to the force constants and positions, and Kong Liu ratio along the minimization. The width of the points is related to the stochastic error.

Figure 2. Evolution of the auxiliary frequencies along the minimization

Be careful that the number of configurations used is rather low and one should check convergence with respect to the number of configurations. One way of checking that is by running a final new step with more configurations starting from the result obtained at the end of the minimization.

2.3 An automatic calculation relaxing also the lattice parameters

Even if the automatic calculation simplifies the procedure enormously, the SSCHA can further simplify the calculations by relaxing also the lattice parameters to a target pressure. This is done by replacing the `relax` feature by the `vcrelax` one as shown in the `sscha_school_2026/Tutorials/01-Free_Energy_Structural_Relaxations/sscha_vcrelax.py` script:

```

1 import cellconstructor as CC, cellconstructor.Phonons
2 import sscha, sscha.Ensemble, sscha.SchaMinimizer
3 import sscha.Relax
4
5 from quippy.potential import Potential
6
7 import sys, os
8
9 import ase
10 import numpy as np
11
12 import warnings
13
14 # NumPy moved ComplexWarning in newer versions. This block keeps the script
15 # compatible with both older and newer NumPy releases.
16 try:
17     ComplexWarning = np.exceptions.ComplexWarning
18 except AttributeError:

```

```

19     ComplexWarning = np.ComplexWarning
20
21 warnings.filterwarnings("ignore", category=ComplexWarning)
22
23 TEMPERATURE = 450 # K
24 NQIRR = 4
25 START_DYN = "../../Materials/CsPbI3_cubic_harmonic_"
26 POTENTIAL = "../../Materials/GAP_1.xml"
27 N_CONFIGS = 50
28
29
30 # Load the harmonic dynamical matrix
31 dyn = CC.Phonons.Phonons(START_DYN, NQIRR)
32
33 # Force positive phonons
34 dyn.ForcePositiveDefinite()
35
36 # Impose symmetries and ASR
37 dyn.Symmetrize()
38
39 # Load the interatomic Potential for CsPbI3
40 calc = Potential("IP GAP", param_filename=POTENTIAL)
41
42 # Run the sscha
43 ensemble = sscha.Ensemble.Ensemble(dyn, TEMPERATURE)
44 minimizer = sscha.SchaMinimizer.SSCHA_Minimizer(ensemble)
45 minimizer.meaningful_factor = 0.000001
46 minimizer.set_minimization_step(0.001)
47 minimizer.kong_liu_ratio = 0.2
48 relax = sscha.Relax.SSCHA(minimizer, calc, N_configs = N_CONFIGS)
49
50 # Setup to save the minimization details every good minimization step
51 # Allows to plot minimization results
52 ioinfo = sscha.Utilities.IOInfo()
53 ioinfo.SetupSaving("minimization_data")
54 relax.setup_custom_functions(custom_function_post = ioinfo.CFP_SaveAll)
55
56 # We perform a variable cell relaxation with the target pressure in GPaf
57 relax.vc_relax(target_press = 0)
58
59 # Save the final ensemble
60 relax.minim.ensemble.save_bin("data", 1)
61 relax.minim.dyn.save_qe("sscha_auxiliary_dyn_")

```

This script can be run as:

```

1 python sscha_vcrelax.py > sscha_vcrelax.log

```

The final auxiliary dynamical matrices in this case will correspond to a different lattice parameter as specified in the `sscha_auxiliary_dyn_` files.

Exercise:

Calculate the lattice parameter as a function of temperature.

You should obtain something like that

Figure 3. Lattice parameter obtained at different temperatures.

As you can see the result is not very smooth although a clear positive trend is seeing. This calculation was performed with only 50 configurations per population. This noisy result suggests that the result can improve with more configurations.

Chapter 3

Hands-on Session 3 - Calculations of Second-Order Phase Transitions with the SSCHA

In this hands-on session, we learn how to calculate second-order phase transitions within the SSCHA.

3.1 Structural Instability: Calculation of the Hessian

According to Landau's theory, a second-order phase transition occurs when the free energy curvature around the high-symmetry structure in the direction of the order parameter becomes negative:

Landau's theory of second-order phase transitions.

Figure 3.1: Landau's theory of second-order phase transitions.

For structural *displacive* phase transitions, the order parameter is associated with phonon atomic displacements:

$$\frac{\partial^2 F}{\partial R_a \partial R_b}$$

where $F(R)$ is the free energy Hessian as a function of the average atomic positions (centroids). is the central quantity for studying second-order phase transitions. The SSCHA provides an analytical equation for the free energy Hessian, derived by Raffaello Bianco in the work [Bianco et al., Phys. Rev. B 96, 014111](#). The free energy curvature can be written as:

$$\frac{\partial^2 F}{\partial R_a \partial R_b} = \Phi_{ab} + \sum_{cdef} {}^{(3)}\Phi_{acd} [1 - \Lambda {}^{(4)}\Phi_{cdef}^{-1}] {}^{(3)}\Phi_{efb}$$

This quantity can be evaluated within SSCHA adopting a sthochastic approach with the function call:

```
1 ensemble.get_free_energy_hessian()
```

In order to provide a practical example while keeping the computational workload low, we employ a toy force field capable of reproducing the essential physics of ferroelectric transitions in FCC lattices. In particular, we focus on the SnTe crystal. SnTe crystallizes at room temperature and ambient pressure in the NaCl

structure (space group $\text{Fm}\bar{3}\text{m}$), known as the β -SnTe phase, where two interpenetrating fcc sublattices of Sn and Te are present. At low temperature, around 100 K, it undergoes a phase transition and stabilizes in a rhombohedral structure (space group $\text{R}\bar{3}\text{m}$), known as the α -SnTe phase. The phase transition can be described as a two-step symmetry reduction: a polar displacement between the two fcc sublattices along the cubic [111] direction, which removes the inversion center, followed by a rhombohedral strain of the unit cell along the same diagonal. In the present work, we concentrate only on the first distortion. We define the interatomic potential $V(u)$ of the toy model as a function of the atomic displacements $u_a = R_a - R_a^{\text{eq}}$ from the equilibrium positions R_a^{eq} of the rock-salt structure, retaining, beyond the quadratic contribution, only the anharmonic third- and fourth-order terms:

$$V(u) = \frac{1}{2} \sum_{ab} \phi_{ab} u^a u^b + \frac{1}{3!} \sum_{abc} \phi_{abc}^{(3)} u^a u^b u^c + \frac{1}{4!} \sum_{abcd} \phi_{abcd}^{(4)} u^a u^b u^c u^d.$$

For the harmonic contribution ϕ_{ab} , we employ the dynamical matrices computed from first principles on a $2 \times 2 \times 2$ q-point grid. The third- and fourth-order force constants are instead parametrized within the toy model. In particular, the third-order term $\phi_{abc}^{(3)}$ is proportional to a single parameter p_3 , while the fourth-order term $\phi_{abcd}^{(4)}$ depends linearly on two parameters, p_4 and $p_{4\chi}$. We will use $p_4 = -0.022, \text{eV}/\text{\AA}^4$, $p_{4\chi} = -0.014, \text{eV}/\text{\AA}^4$, and $p_3 = 0.036475, \text{eV}/\text{\AA}^3$.

The harmonic phono dispersion along an high-symmetry path of the Brillouin zone (BZ) can be obtained with this script:

```

1 import cellconstructor.Phonons
2 import cellconstructor.ForceTensor
3 import cellconstructor.Methods
4
5 import matplotlib.pyplot as plt
6
7 NQIRR = 3
8 PATH = "GXMGR"
9 N_POINTS = 1000
10
11 SPECIAL_POINTS = {
12     "G": [0.0, 0.0, 0.0],
13     "X": [0.5, 0.0, 0.0],
14     "M": [0.5, 0.5, 0.0],
15     "R": [0.5, 0.5, 0.5],
16 }
17
18 # Load HARM phonons
19 harm_dyn = cellconstructor.Phonons.Phonons("ffield_dynq_", NQIRR)
20
21
22 # Get band path
23 qpath, data = cellconstructor.Methods.get_bandpath(
24     harm_dyn.structure.unit_cell,
25     PATH,
26     SPECIAL_POINTS,
27     N_POINTS)
28
29 axis, xticks, xlabel = data
30
31 # Fourier interpolation along q-path
32 harm_dispersion = cellconstructor.ForceTensor.get_phonons_in_qpath(
33     harm_dyn,
34     qpath)
35
36 nmodes = harm_dyn.structure.N_atoms * 3
37

```

```

38 plt.figure(dpi=150)
39 ax = plt.gca()
40
41 for i in range(nmodes):
42     ax.plot(
43         xaxis,
44         harm_dispersion[:, i],
45         color="r",
46         lw=1)
47
48 for x in xticks:
49     ax.axvline(x, 0, 1, color="k", lw=0.4)
50
51 ax.axhline(0, 0, 1, color="k", ls=":", lw=0.4)
52
53 ax.set_xticks(xticks)
54 ax.set_xticklabels(xlabels)
55
56 ax.set_xlabel("Q path")
57 ax.set_ylabel("Phonons [cm$^{-1}$]")
58
59 plt.tight_layout()
60 plt.savefig("harm_dispersion.png", dpi=300)
61 plt.show()

```

Harmonic phonon dispersion of SnTe.

The dynamical instability observed at the harmonic level signals that the system may undergo a spontaneous phase transition as the temperature decreases.

As a first step, let us compute the SSCHA dynamical matrix for SnTe at different temperatures. At $T = 0$ K, we proceed with this script:

```

1  import os
2  import numpy as np
3  import warnings
4
5  # CellConstructor modules
6  import cellconstructor as CC
7  import cellconstructor.Phonons
8
9  # SSCHA modules
10 import sscha
11 import sscha.Ensemble
12 import sscha.SchaMinimizer
13 import sscha.Relax
14
15 # Toy-model force field
16 import fforces as ff
17 import fforces.Calculator
18
19
20 # =====
21 # Ignore NumPy ComplexWarning generated during SSCHA updates
22 # =====
23
24 try:
25     ComplexWarning = np.exceptions.ComplexWarning
26 except AttributeError:
27     ComplexWarning = np.ComplexWarning

```

```

28 warnings.filterwarnings("ignore", category=ComplexWarning)
29
30
31
32 # =====
33 # INPUT PARAMETERS
34 # =====
35
36 # Temperature in Kelvin
37 TEMPERATURE = 0
38
39 # Number of irreducible q-points
40 NQIRR = 3
41
42 # Number of configurations used in the SSCHA ensemble
43 N_CONFIGS = 256
44
45 # Prefix of the starting dynamical matrices
46 START_DYN = "/home/raffaello/SSCHA2026/HARM/ffield_dynq_"
47
48 # Dynamical matrices used to define the harmonic reference of the toy model
49 MODEL_DYN = "/home/raffaello/SSCHA2026/HARM/ffield_dynq_"
50
51
52 # =====
53 # DEFINE THE TOY FORCE FIELD
54 # =====
55
56 # Load the harmonic dynamical matrices
57 ff_dyn = CC.Phonons.Phonons(MODEL_DYN, NQIRR)
58
59 # Create the toy-model calculator
60 ff_calculator = ff.Calculator.ToyModelCalculator(ff_dyn)
61
62 # Select the type of anharmonic toy potential
63 ff_calculator.type_cal = "pbtex"
64
65 # Anharmonic parameters
66 ff_calculator.p3 = 0.036475
67 ff_calculator.p4 = -0.022
68 ff_calculator.p4x = -0.014
69
70
71 # =====
72 # CREATE OUTPUT DIRECTORY
73 # =====
74
75 output_dir = f"T_{TEMPERATURE}"
76 os.makedirs(output_dir, exist_ok=True)
77
78 # =====
79 # LOAD STARTING DYNAMICAL MATRICES
80 # =====
81
82 start_dyn = CC.Phonons.Phonons(START_DYN, NQIRR)
83
84 # If the starting dynamical matrices are not positive definite
85 # (i.e. imaginary phonon frequencies are present),
86 # enforce positive definiteness and

```

```

87 # reimpose crystal symmetries and acoustic sum rule.
88
89 w, pols = start_dyn.DiagonalizeSupercell()
90
91 w_sorted = np.sort(w)
92 tol = -1e-4
93
94 if np.min(w_sorted[3:]) < tol:
95     print("Non-acoustic imaginary phonon modes detected")
96     start_dyn.ForcePositiveDefinite()
97     start_dyn.Symmetrize()
98
99
100 # =====
101 # CREATE SSCHA ENSEMBLE
102 # =====
103
104 ensemble = sscha.Ensemble.Ensemble(
105     start_dyn,
106     TEMPERATURE
107 )
108
109
110 # =====
111 # SETUP THE SSCHA MINIMIZER
112 # =====
113
114 minimizer = sscha.SchaMinimizer.SSCHA_Minimizer(ensemble)
115
116 # Control minimization stability and convergence
117 minimizer.meaningful_factor = 0.01
118 minimizer.set_minimization_step(0.001)
119
120
121 # =====
122 # SETUP SSCHA RELAXATION
123 # =====
124
125 relax = sscha.Relax.SSCHA(
126     minimizer,
127     ase_calculator=ff_calculator,
128     N_configs=N_CONFIGS
129 )
130
131
132 # =====
133 # RUN THE SSCHA MINIMIZATION
134 # =====
135
136 relax.relax()
137
138
139 # =====
140 # SAVE FINAL SSCHA DYNAMICAL MATRICES
141 # =====
142
143 relax.minim.dyn.save_qe(
144     os.path.join(output_dir, "sscha_dyn_")
145 )

```

Plotting the phonon dispersion of the SSCHA dynamical matrices together with the harmonic phonon dispersion, we obtain the following result.

Harmonic vs SSCHA phonon dispersion at T=0 K.

```

1 import os
2 import numpy as np
3 import warnings
4
5 import cellconstructor as CC
6 import cellconstructor.Phonons
7
8 import sscha.Ensemble
9 import sscha.SchaMinimizer
10 import sscha.Relax
11
12 import fforces as ff
13 import fforces.Calculator
14
15
16 # =====
17 # Ignore NumPy ComplexWarning generated during SSCHA updates
18 # =====
19
20 try:
21     ComplexWarning = np.exceptions.ComplexWarning
22 except AttributeError:
23     ComplexWarning = np.ComplexWarning
24
25 warnings.filterwarnings("ignore", category=ComplexWarning)
26
27
28 # =====
29 # INPUT PARAMETERS
30 # =====
31
32 TEMPERATURE = 0
33 NQIRR = 3
34
35 N_CONFIGS = 2000
36
37 # Already relaxed SSCHA dynamical matrices
38 SSCHA_DYN = f"/home/raffaello/SSCHA2026/RELAX/T_{TEMPERATURE}/sscha_dyn_"
39
40 # Dynamical matrices defining the harmonic part of the toy model
41 MODEL_DYN = "/home/raffaello/SSCHA2026/HARM/ffield_dynq_"
42
43
44 # =====
45 # DEFINE THE TOY FORCE FIELD
46 # =====
47
48 # Load the harmonic dynamical matrices
49 ff_dyn = CC.Phonons.Phonons(MODEL_DYN, NQIRR)
50
51 # Create the toy-model calculator
52 ff_calculator = ff.Calculator.ToyModelCalculator(ff_dyn)
53
54 # Select the type of anharmonic toy potential
55 ff_calculator.type_cal = "pbtex"

```

```

56
57 # Anharmonic parameters
58 ff_calculator.p3 = 0.036475
59 ff_calculator.p4 = -0.022
60 ff_calculator.p4x = -0.014
61
62
63
64 # =====
65 # LOAD RELAXED SSCHA DYNAMICAL MATRICES
66 # =====
67
68 sscha_dyn = CC.Phonons.Phonons(SSCHA_DYN, NQIRR)
69 sscha_dyn.Symmetrize()
70
71 # =====
72 # CREATE SSCHA ENSEMBLE
73 # =====
74
75 ensemble = sscha.Ensemble.Ensemble(
76     sscha_dyn,
77     TEMPERATURE
78 )
79
80
81 # =====
82 # SETUP THE SSCHA MINIMIZER
83 # =====
84
85 minimizer = sscha.SchaMinimizer.SSCHA_Minimizer(ensemble)
86
87 # Control minimization stability and convergence
88 minimizer.meaningful_factor = 0.01
89 minimizer.set_minimization_step(0.001)
90
91
92 # =====
93 # SETUP SSCHA RELAXATION
94 # =====
95
96 relax = sscha.Relax.SSCHA(
97     minimizer,
98     ase_calculator=ff_calculator,
99     N_configs=N_CONFIGS
100 )
101
102
103 # =====
104 # RUN THE SSCHA MINIMIZATION
105 # =====
106
107 relax.relax()
108
109 # =====
110 # SAVE FINAL SSCHA DYNAMICAL MATRICES
111 # =====
112
113 relax.minim.dyn.save_qe("refined_sscha_dyn_")
114

```

```

115
116
117 # Reweight the ensemble using the refined dynamical matrix
118 ensemble.update_weights(minimizer.dyn, TEMPERATURE)
119
120 # Compute the free-energy Hessian
121 dyn_hessian = ensemble.get_free_energy_hessian(
122     include_v4=False,
123     get_full_hessian=True,
124     return_d3=False,
125 )
126
127 # Save the Hessian dynamical matrix
128 dyn_hessian.save_qe("hessian_dyn_")
129
130
131 print("\nDone.")

```

Frequency vs number of configurations.

Frequency vs inverse square root of the number of configurations.

1. Load the metrics and generate the ensemble

```
new_ensemble = sscha.Ensemble.Ensemble(dyn, T) new_ensemble.generate(N) new_ensemble.compute_ensemble(calculator)
```

Chapter 4

Compute the free energy hessian on the final dynamical matrix after

```
minimization with the importance sampling hessian = new_minim.ensemble.get_free_energy_hessian(include_v4 = False)
```


Chapter 5

Save it in QE dynamical matrix format

```
hessian.save_qe("hessian_v3_")
```

1. First, we prepare the Toy model force field that substitutes the usual ab initio calculations for this tutorial. This force field needs the harmonic dynamical matrix to be initialized, along with the higher-order parameters. Finally, the dynamical matrix for the minimization is loaded and ready. Since we are studying a system that has a spontaneous symmetry breaking at low temperature, the harmonic dynamical matrices will have imaginary phonons. We must enforce phonons to be positive definite to start an SSCHA minimization.

```
1  # Load the dynamical matrix for the force field
2  ff_dyn = CC.Phonons.Phonons("ffield_dynq", 3)
3
4  # Setup the forcefield with the correct parameters
5  ff_calculator = ff.Calculator.ToyModelCalculator(ff_dyn)
6  ff_calculator.type_cal = "pbtex"
7  ff_calculator.p3 = 0.036475
8  ff_calculator.p4 = -0.022
9  ff_calculator.p4x = -0.014
10
11 # Initialization of the SSCHA matrix
12 dyn_sscha = CC.Phonons.Phonons(Files_dyn_SnTe, nqirr)
13 # Flip the imaginary frequencies into real ones
14 dyn_sscha.ForcePositiveDefinite()
15 # Apply the ASR and the symmetry group
16 dyn_sscha.Symmetrize()
```

2. The next step is to create the ensemble for the specified temperature. As an extra, we also look for the space group of the structure.

```
1  ensemble = sscha.Ensemble.Ensemble(dyn_sscha,
2      T0 = Temperature, supercell = dyn_sscha.GetSupercell())
3  # Detect space group
4  symm=spglib.get_spacegroup(dyn_sscha.structure.get_ase_atoms(),
5      0.005)
6  print('Initial SG = ', symm)
```

3. Next comes the minimization step. Here we can set the fourth root minimization, in which, instead of optimizing the auxiliary dynamical matrices themselves, we optimize their fourth root.

$$\Phi = \left(\sqrt[4]{\Phi} \right)^4$$

This constrains the dynamical matrix to be positive definite during the minimization. Next, the automatic relaxation is set with the option to use the Sobol sequence for the ensemble generation.

We also set a custom function to save the frequencies at each iteration, to see how they evolve. This is very useful for understanding whether the algorithm has converged.

Then, the dynamical matrix of the converged minimization is saved to a file, and finally we take a look at the space group and the structure.

```

1  minim = sscha.SchaMinimizer.SSCHA_Minimizer(ensemble)
2
3  # Now we setup the minimization parameters
4  # Since we are quite far from the correct solution,
5  # we will use a small optimization step
6  minim.set_minimization_step(0.25)
7
8  # Reduce the threshold for the gradient convergence
9  minim.meaningful_factor = 0.01
10
11 # If the minimization ends with few steps (less than 10),
12 # decrease it, if it takes too much, increase it
13
14 # We decrease the Kong-Liu effective sample size below
15 # which the population is stopped
16 minim.kong_liu_ratio = 0.5 # Default 0.5
17 # We relax the structure
18 relax = sscha.Relax.SSCHA(minim,
19                             ase_calculator = ff_calculator,
20                             N_configs = configurations,
21                             max_pop = 50)
22
23 # Setup the custom function to print the frequencies
24 # at each step of the minimization
25 io_func = sscha.Utilities.IOInfo()
26 io_func.SetupSaving(File_frequencies)
27 # The file that will contain the frequencies is frequencies.dat
28
29 # Now tell relax to call the function to save the frequencies
30 # after each iteration
31 # CFP stands for Custom Function Post (Post = after the minimization step)
32 #relax.setup_custom_functions(custom_function_post = io_func.CFP_SaveFrequencies)
33 relax.setup_custom_functions(custom_function_post = io_func.CFP_SaveAll)
34 # Finally we do all the free energy calculations.
35 relax.relax()
36 #relax.vc_relax(static_bulk_modulus=40, fix_volume = False)
37
38 # Save the final dynamical matrix
39 relax.minim.dyn.save_qe(File_final_dyn)
40 # Detect space group
41 symm=spglib.get_spacegroup(relax.minim.dyn.structure.get_ase_atoms(),
42                             0.005)
43 print('New SG = ', symm)
44 view(relax.minim.dyn.structure.get_ase_atoms())

```

This code will calculate the SSCHA minimization with the `ff_calculator`. We can use `sscha-plot-data.py` to take a look at the minimization.

```
1 python sscha-plot-data.py frequencies.dat
```

Minimization figures

Figure 5.1: Minimization figures

Frequencies minimization

Figure 5.2: Frequencies minimization

Note: this force field model is not able to compute stress, as it is defined only at fixed volume, so we cannot use it for a variable cell relaxation.

Now we can search for instabilities.

If we have a very small mode in the SSCHA frequencies, it means that associated with that mode we have huge fluctuations. This can indicate an instability. However, to test this we need to compute the free energy curvature along this mode. This can be obtained in one shot thanks to the theory developed in [Bianco et al., Phys. Rev. B 96, 014111](#).

For that, we create another program to do the job.

As before, we begin by importing some libraries and setting variables:

```
1  #!/usr/bin/env python
2  # -*- coding: utf-8 -*-
3  #
4  #  SSCHA_exercise_Unstable.py
5  #
6  # Import the cellconstructor stuff
7  import cellconstructor as CC
8  import cellconstructor.Phonons
9  import cellconstructor.ForceTensor
10 import cellconstructor.Structure
11 import cellconstructor.Spectral
12
13 # Import the modules of the force field
14 import ffrces as ff
15 import ffrces.Calculator
16
17 # Import the modules to run the sscha
18 import sscha, sscha.Ensemble, sscha.SchaMinimizer
19 import sscha.Relax, sscha.Utilities
20
21 import spglib
22 from ase.visualize import view
23
24 # Import Matplotlib to plot
25 import numpy as np
26 import matplotlib.pyplot as plt
27 from matplotlib import cm
28 import timeit
29
30 #Setting the variables:
31 #Setting the temperature in Kelvin:
32 Temperature = 0
33 #Setting the number of configurations:
34 configurations = 50
35 #Setting the names and location of the files:
```

```

36 Files_dyn_SnTe = "ffield_dynq"
37 #Set the number of irreducible q (related to the supercell size):
38 nqirr = 3
39 #Setting the frequencies output file:
40 File_frequencies = "frequencies.dat"
41 #Setting the dynamical matrix output filename:
42 File_final_dyn = "final_sscha_T{}_".format(int(Temperature))

```

Now we look for that instability:

1. The ff_calculator toy potential is defined as we have seen in the previous program.

```

1  # Load the dynamical matrix for the force field
2  ff_dyn = CC.Phonons.Phonons("ffield_dynq", 3)
3
4  # Setup the forcefield with the correct parameters
5  ff_calculator = ff.Calculator.ToyModelCalculator(ff_dyn)
6  ff_calculator.type_cal = "pbtex"
7  ff_calculator.p3 = 0.036475
8  ff_calculator.p4 = -0.022
9  ff_calculator.p4x = -0.014
10
11 # Initialization of the SSCHA matrix
12 dyn_sscha = CC.Phonons.Phonons(Files_dyn_SnTe, nqirr)
13 dyn_sscha.ForcePositiveDefinite()
14
15 # Apply also the ASR and the symmetry group
16 dyn_sscha.Symmetrize()

```

2. Next, we load the dynamical matrix calculated previously with the ff_calculator toy potential, so there is no need to calculate it again.

```

1  # The SSCHA dynamical matrix is needed (the one after convergence)
2  # We reload the final result (no need to rerun the sscha minimization)
3  dyn_sscha_final = CC.Phonons.Phonons(File_final_dyn, nqirr)

```

3. Then, since the Hessian calculation is more sensitive, we generate a new ensemble with more configurations. To compute the Hessian we will use an ensemble of 10000 configurations. Note that we can use fewer if we use the Sobol sequence, or we can load a previously generated ensemble.

```

1  # We reset the ensemble
2  ensemble = sscha.Ensemble.Ensemble(dyn_sscha_final, T0 = Temperature,
3                                     supercell = dyn_sscha_final.GetSupercell())
4
5  # We need a bigger ensemble to properly compute the hessian
6  # Here we will use 10000 configurations
7  ensemble.generate(5000, sobol = True)
8  #ensemble.generate(10000, sobol = False)
9  #We could also load the ensemble with
10 # ensemble.load("data_ensemble_final", N = 100, population = 5)

```

4. We now compute forces and energies using the force field calculator.

```

1  # We now compute forces and energies using the force field calculator
2  ensemble.get_energy_forces(ff_calculator, compute_stress = False)

```

5. Finally, the free energy Hessian is calculated with the get_free_energy_hessian function. We can choose whether to neglect or include the four-phonon scattering process. Four-phonon scattering processes

require a huge memory allocation for big systems, scaling as $(3N)^4$ with N the number of atoms in the supercell. Moreover, they may also require more configurations to converge.

In almost all the systems we have studied up to now, we found this four-phonon scattering at high order to be negligible. We remark that the SSCHA minimization already includes four-phonon scattering at the lowest order perturbation theory; thus, neglecting this term only affects combinations of one or more four-phonon scattering with two three-phonon scatterings (high-order diagrams). For more details, see [Bianco et al., Phys. Rev. B 96, 014111](#).

We can then print the frequencies of the Hessian. If an imaginary frequency is present, then the system wants to spontaneously break the high-symmetry phase.

```

1  print("Updating the importance sampling...")
2  # If the sscha matrix was not the one used to compute the ensemble
3  # We must update the ensemble weights
4  # We can also use this function to simulate a different temperature.
5  ensemble.update_weights(dyn_sscha_final, Temperature)
6  # ----- COMPUTE THE FREE ENERGY HESSIAN -----
7  print("Computing the free energy hessian...")
8  dyn_hessian = ensemble.get_free_energy_hessian(include_v4 = False)
9  # We neglect high-order four phonon scattering
10 dyn_hessian = ensemble.get_free_energy_hessian(include_v4 = True,
11 #           get_full_hessian = True, verbose = True) # Full calculus
12 # We can save the free energy hessian as a dynamical matrix
13 # in quantum espresso format
14 dyn_hessian.save_qe("hessian")
15 # -----
16 # We calculate the frequencies of the hessian:
17 w_hessian, pols_hessian = dyn_hessian.DiagonalizeSupercell()
18
19 # Print all the frequency converting them into cm-1 (They are in Ry)
20 print("\n".join(["{:16.4f} cm-1".format(w * CC.Units.RY_TO_CM) for w in w_hessian])
    )

```

The frequencies in the free energy Hessian are temperature dependent.

We can look at the eigenmodes of the free energy Hessian to check if we have imaginary phonons. If there are negative frequencies, then we have found an instability. You can check what happens if you include the fourth order.

Exercise:

The Sobol sequences reduce the number of configurations by providing a better mapping of the Gaussian than a random distribution. By uniformly spreading the samples with a low-discrepancy sequence like Sobol, it is possible to reduce the number of configurations needed. Low-discrepancy sequences tend to sample space “more uniformly” than random numbers. Algorithms that use such sequences may have superior convergence. You can test this in the calculation of the Hessian by changing the number of configurations and the mapping scheme in the `ensemble.generate()` function.

5.1 Second Order Phase Transition

Up to now, we studied the system at $T = 0$ K and found that there is an instability. However, we can repeat the minimization at many temperatures and track the phonon frequency to see at which temperature the system becomes stable.

Again, we load and set the variables. Now we have several temperatures, so we store them in an array:

```

1  #!/usr/bin/env python

```

```

2  # -*- coding: utf-8 -*-
3  #
4  #  SSCHA_exercise_Unstable.py
5  #
6  # Import the cellconstructor stuff
7  import cellconstructor as CC
8  import cellconstructor.Phonons
9  import cellconstructor.ForceTensor
10 import cellconstructor.Structure
11 import cellconstructor.Spectral
12
13 # Import the modules of the force field
14 import fforces as ff
15 import fforces.Calculator
16
17 # Import the modules to run the sscha
18 import sscha, sscha.Ensemble, sscha.SchaMinimizer
19 import sscha.Relax, sscha.Utilities
20
21 import spglib
22 from ase.visualize import view
23
24 # Import Matplotlib to plot
25 import numpy as np
26 import matplotlib.pyplot as plt
27 from matplotlib import cm
28 import timeit
29
30 #Setting the variables:
31 #Setting the temperature in Kelvin:
32 Temperature = 0
33 #Setting the number of configurations:
34 configurations = 50
35 #Setting the names and location of the files:
36 Files_dyn_SnTe = "ffield_dynq"
37 #Set the number of irreducible q (related to the supercell size):
38 nqirr = 3
39 #Setting the frequencies output file:
40 File_frequencies = "frequencies.dat"
41 #Setting the dynamical matrix output filename:
42 File_final_dyn = "final_sscha_T{}_".format(int(Temperature))
43 sobol = False
44 sobol_scatter = False

```

1. Like in the previous program, first we prepare the Toy model force field:

```

1  # Load the dynamical matrix for the force field
2  ff_dyn = CC.Phonons.Phonons("ffield_dynq", 3)
3
4  # Setup the forcefield with the correct parameters
5  ff_calculator = ff.Calculator.ToyModelCalculator(ff_dyn)
6  ff_calculator.type_cal = "pbtex"
7  ff_calculator.p3 = 0.036475
8  ff_calculator.p4 = -0.022
9  ff_calculator.p4x = -0.014

```

2. We are going to need a range of temperatures for this calculation:

```

1  # Define the temperatures, from 50 to 300 K, 6 temperatures

```

```

2  temperatures = np.linspace(50, 300, 6)
3
4  lowest_hessian_mode = []
5  lowest_sscha_mode = []
6
7  # Perform a simulation at each temperature
8  t_old = Temperature

```

3. In the next part, we condense the calculation of the Hessians in a loop over different temperatures. At the end, it searches for the lowest non-acoustic frequency and saves it together with the corresponding auxiliary SSCHA frequency.

```

1  for Temperature in temperatures:
2      # Load the starting dynamical matrix
3      dyn = CC.Phonons.Phonons(File_final_dyn.format(int(t_old)), nqirr)
4
5      # Prepare the ensemble
6      ensemble = sscha.Ensemble.Ensemble(dyn, T0 = Temperature,
7                                          supercell = dyn.GetSupercell())
8
9      # Prepare the minimizer
10     minim = sscha.SchaMinimizer.SSCHA_Minimizer(ensemble)
11     minim.min_step_struc = 0.05
12     minim.min_step_dyn = 0.002
13     minim.kong_liu_ratio = 0.5
14     minim.meaningful_factor = 0.000001
15     #minim.root_representation = "root4"
16     #minim.precond_dyn = False
17     #minim.minim_struct = True
18     #minim.neglect_symmetries = True
19     minim.enforce_sum_rule = True # Lorenzo's solution to the error
20
21     # Prepare the relaxer (through many population)
22     relax = sscha.Relax.SSCHA(minim, ase_calculator = ff_calculator,
23                               N_configs=configurations, max_pop=20)
24
25     # Relax
26     relax.relax(sobol = sobol, sobol_scramble = sobol_scatter)
27     #relax.relax()
28
29     # Save the dynamical matrix
30     relax.minim.dyn.save_qe(File_final_dyn.format(int(Temperature)))
31
32     # Detect space group
33     symm=spglib.get_spacegroup(relax.minim.dyn.structure.get_ase_atoms(),
34                                0.005)
35     print('Current SG = ', symm, ' at T=',int(Temperature))
36
37     # Recompute the ensemble for the hessian calculation
38     ensemble = sscha.Ensemble.Ensemble(relax.minim.dyn, T0 = Temperature,
39                                         supercell = dyn.GetSupercell())
40     ensemble.generate(configurations, sobol = sobol,
41                      sobol_scramble = sobol_scatter)
42     ensemble.get_energy_forces(ff_calculator, compute_stress = False)
43     #gets the energies and forces from ff_calculator
44
45     #update weights!!!
46     ensemble.update_weights(relax.minim.dyn, Temperature)
47     # Get the free energy hessian

```

```

48     dyn_hessian = ensemble.get_free_energy_hessian(include_v4 = False)
49     #free energy hessian as in Bianco paper 2017
50     dyn_hessian.save_qe("hessian_T{}_".format(int(Temperature)))
51
52     # Get the lowest frequencies for the sscha and the free energy hessian
53     w_sscha, pols_sscha = relax.minim.dyn.DiagonalizeSupercell() #dynamical matrix
54     # Get the structure in the supercell
55     superstructure = relax.minim.dyn.structure.generate_supercell(relax.minim.dyn.
        GetSupercell())
56
57     # Discard the acoustic modes
58     acoustic_modes = CC.Methods.get_translations(pols_sscha,
59         superstructure.get_masses_array())
60     w_sscha = w_sscha[~acoustic_modes]
61
62     lowest_sscha_mode.append(np.min(w_sscha) * CC.Units.RY_TO_CM) # Convert from Ry
        to cm-1
63
64     w_hessian, pols_hessian = dyn_hessian.DiagonalizeSupercell() #recomputed dyn
        for hessian
65     # Discard the acoustic modes
66     acoustic_modes = CC.Methods.get_translations(pols_hessian,
67         superstructure.get_masses_array())
68     w_hessian = w_hessian[~acoustic_modes]
69     lowest_hessian_mode.append(np.min(w_hessian) * CC.Units.RY_TO_CM) # Convert
        from Ry to cm-1
70     #print ("\n".join(["{: .4f} cm-1".format(w * CC.Units.RY_TO_CM) for w in
        pols_hessian]))
71     #exit()
72
73     t_old = Temperature
74     # We prepare now the file to save the results
75     freq_data = np.zeros( (len(temperatures), 3))
76     freq_data[:, 0] = temperatures
77     freq_data[:, 1] = lowest_sscha_mode
78     freq_data[:, 2] = lowest_hessian_mode
79
80     # Save results on file
81     np.savetxt("{}_hessian_vs_temperature.dat".format(configurations),
82         freq_data, header = "T [K]; SSCHA mode [cm-1]; Free energy hessian [cm
        -1]")

```

4. Finally, we produce a graphical output of the data.

```

1     hessian_data = np.loadtxt("{}_hessian_vs_temperature.dat".format(configurations))
2
3     plt.figure(dpi = 120)
4     plt.plot(hessian_data[:,0], hessian_data[:,1],
5         label = "Min SCHA freq", marker = ">")
6     plt.plot(hessian_data[:,0], hessian_data[:,2],
7         label = "Free energy curvature", marker = "o")
8     plt.axhline(0, 0, 1, color = "k", ls = "dotted") # Draw the zero
9     plt.xlabel("Temperature [K]")
10    plt.ylabel("Frequency [cm-1]")
11    plt.legend()
12    plt.tight_layout()
13    plt.savefig('{}_Temp_Freq.png'.format(configurations))
14    #plt.show()
15

```



```

16 plt.figure(dpi = 120)
17 plt.plot(hessian_data[:,0], np.sign(hessian_data[:,2]) * hessian_data[:,2]**2,
18          label = "Free energy curvature", marker = "o")
19 plt.axhline(0, 0, 1, color = "k", ls = "dotted") # Draw the zero
20 plt.xlabel("Temperature [K]")
21 plt.ylabel("$\omega^2$ [cm-2]")
22 plt.legend()
23 plt.tight_layout()
24 plt.savefig('{}_Temp_Omeg.png'.format(configurations))
25 #plt.show()

```

We will simulate temperatures up to room temperature (300 K) with steps of 50 K. Note that this will perform all the steps above 6 times, so it may take some minutes depending on the PC (on an i3 from 2015, with one core, it took 2 hours). If it takes too long, you can reduce the number of steps by changing the temperature array in `Temperature_i = np.linspace(50, 300, 6)`.

Frequencies versus Temperatures

Figure 5.3: Frequencies versus Temperatures

In the figure above, we can see that the phase transition is between 100 K and 150 K. The data points do not form a linear figure. We can increase the number of temperature points to locate the exact transition temperature, but there is another better way to find it.

Squared frequencies versus Temperatures

Figure 5.4: Squared frequencies versus Temperatures

For the Landau theory of phase transitions, since the SSCHA is a mean-field approach, we expect that around the transition the critical exponent of the temperature goes as:

$$\omega \sim \sqrt{\Phi}$$

For this reason, it is better to plot the temperature versus the square of the frequency, as in the figure above. This makes the graph linear, so we can easily estimate the critical temperature by linear interpolation.

We are using only 50 configurations in the ensemble. Note that this makes the calculation fast, but it is a low number for these calculations because the free energy calculations are noisier than the SSCHA frequencies. This is because the computation of the free energy requires the third-order force constant tensor, which requires more configurations to converge.

Exercise:

How does the calculation of the free energy change with the number of configurations?

Evolution of the lowest *soft* frequency in relation to the number of configurations in the ensemble with a stable configuration. The line is the mean and the shade is the standard deviation.

Figure 5.5: Evolution of the lowest *soft* frequency in relation to the number of configurations in the ensemble with a stable configuration. The line is the mean and the shade is the standard deviation.

Exercise:

Plot the Hessian phonon dispersion.

Hessian phonon dispersion

Figure 5.6: Hessian phonon dispersion

Workflow of the SSCHA objects for: A) Free energy minimization; B) Structural instabilities search; C) Temperature loop for second order phase transition code. Dotted lines are functions within objects. The dotted and dashed lines indicate the relationship of the dynamic matrix to the objects.

Figure 5.7: Workflow of the SSCHA objects for: A) Free energy minimization; B) Structural instabilities search; C) Temperature loop for second order phase transition code. Dotted lines are functions within objects. The dotted and dashed lines indicate the relationship of the dynamic matrix to the objects.

Chapter 6

Hands-on Session 3 - Spectral functions, Raman and infrared spectra with the Time-Dependent SSCHA

6.1 Setup

This tutorial focuses on the computation of dynamical properties of materials. To run, it requires the `quippy-ase` force field, a converged SSCHA calculation on the system CsPbI_3 , and the DFT calculation of Raman tensor and Born effective charges. You can find all the materials inside the `Materials/tutorial_03` folder of the repository. Copy all these files in your working directory. Also, remember to adjust the relative path to the `GAP_1.xml` file for the force field with respect to your working directory in all the scripts.

To run the calculations, be sure to be inside the anaconda `sscha` environment. To enter in this environment, from the terminal run

```
1 conda activate sscha
```

This command needs to be run every time a new terminal is open. If you have not yet done so, once inside the `sscha` environment, install `quippy-ase` with the command

```
1 pip install quippy-ase
```

6.2 Theoretical background

The key quantity which is measured by experiments is the *dynamical response function* $\chi(\omega)$. The response function probes how the material responds to a time-dependent external perturbation. We can model any experiment as follows: the material is in equilibrium for $t < t_0$, then a perturbation is turned on at t_0 , and we measure a property A at a later time t . The measured response is the convolution of the perturbation over all intervening times, weighted by the response function $\chi(t - t')$, which describes how perturbations propagate in time:

$$A(t) = A_0 + \int_{t_0}^t dt' \chi(t - t') F(t')$$

where $F(t')$ is the external time-dependent perturbation, and A_0 is the value of the property A in equilibrium. Alternatively, in Fourier space, the convolution becomes a simple product:

$$A(\omega) = A_0 + \chi(\omega) F(\omega)$$

This is very general, and it applies to any experiment. In this tutorial, we focus on IR and Raman spectroscopy. For the case of IR, the perturbation is the electric field of the light, which interacts with the material by generating an oscillating dipole. The response of the material is the *emitted* (or absorbed) electric field, which is related to how the dipole moment of the material oscillates in time. So the observable $A(t)$ is the dipole moment of the material, and the perturbation $F(t)$ is the amplitude of the electric field of the light.

The Kubo equation for the response function is

$$\chi(t) = \frac{i}{\hbar} \theta(t) \langle M(t) M(0) \rangle$$

where $\hat{M}(t)$ is the dipole moment operator in the Heisenberg picture, and $\langle \cdot \rangle$ is the quantum average at finite temperature. The Time-Dependent SSCHA (TD-SCHA) extends the SSCHA framework to compute dynamical response functions. Here we will use the Lanczos algorithm to compute the response function in Fourier space, which is more efficient than computing it in time and then Fourier transforming it.

The first step is to convert the dipole operator in phonons creation and annihilation operators. To this aim, we can approximate the dipole moment as a linear function of the atomic displacements $\hat{u}$:

$$\hat{M}(t) = \left. \frac{\partial M}{\partial u} \right|_{u=0} \hat{u}(t) + O(u^2)$$

The derivative of the dipole moment with respect to the atomic displacements is precisely the Born effective charge:

$$Z_{\alpha\beta}^i = \frac{\partial M_\alpha}{\partial u_\beta^i} = \frac{\partial^2 \mathcal{E}}{\partial u_\beta^i \partial E_\alpha}$$

where E_α is the electric field in the α Cartesian direction, u_β^i is the displacement of atom i in the β Cartesian direction, and $\mathcal{E}$ is the total energy of the system (Born-Oppenheimer). Using this in the expression of the susceptibility, we obtain:

$$\chi_{\text{IR}\alpha}(t) = \sum_{ij} \sum_{\beta\gamma} \frac{Z_{\alpha\beta}^i Z_{\alpha\gamma}^j}{\sqrt{m_i m_j}} \sqrt{m_i m_j} \langle \hat{u}_\beta^i(t) \hat{u}_\gamma^j(0) \rangle$$

The last term is the so-called phonon Green's function, which represents the propagation of a phonon created at time $t = 0$ and destroyed at time t .

$$G_{\alpha\beta}^{ij}(t) = \sqrt{m_i m_j} \langle \hat{u}_\alpha^i(t) \hat{u}_\beta^j(0) \rangle$$

Analogously, the Raman spectrum is related to the response of the material to two electric fields, which interact with the material by generating an oscillating polarizability. The observable $A(t)$ is the polarizability of the material, and the perturbation $F(t)$ is the amplitude of the two overlapping electric fields which interfere within the material. The Raman susceptibility can be written as:

$$\chi_{\text{Raman}}(t) = \langle \hat{\alpha}_{\alpha\beta}(t) \hat{\alpha}_{\alpha\beta}(0) \rangle$$

where $\hat{\alpha}_{\alpha\beta}$ is the polarizability operator, which can be approximated as a linear function of the atomic displacements:

$$\hat{\alpha}_{\alpha\beta}(t) = \left. \frac{\partial \alpha_{\alpha\beta}}{\partial u_\gamma^i} \right|_{u=0} \hat{u}_\gamma^i(t) + O(u^2)$$

$$\Xi_{\alpha\beta\gamma}^i = \frac{\partial \alpha_{\alpha\beta}}{\partial u_\gamma^i} = \frac{\partial^3 \mathcal{E}}{\partial u_\gamma^i \partial E_\alpha \partial E_\beta}$$

where $\Xi_{\alpha\beta\gamma}^i$ is the Raman tensor, which is the third derivative of the total energy (Born-Oppenheimer) with respect to the atomic displacements and the two electric fields (incoming-outgoing).

Notably, the Raman requires two electric fields because it is a scattering, where incoming and outgoing radiation are different. The IR instead is an absorption/emission, where incoming and outgoing radiation are the same.

The Raman susceptibility is then:

$$\chi_{\text{Raman}}(t) = \langle \hat{\alpha}_{\alpha\beta}(t) \hat{\alpha}_{\alpha\beta}(0) \rangle = \sum_{ij} \sum_{\gamma\delta} \frac{\Xi_{\alpha\beta\gamma}^i \Xi_{\alpha\beta\delta}^j}{\sqrt{m_i m_j}} \sqrt{m_i m_j} \langle \hat{u}_{\gamma}^i(t) \hat{u}_{\delta}^j(0) \rangle$$

Also here, the last term is the phonon Green's function, which represents the propagation of a phonon created at time $t = 0$ and destroyed at time t . Therefore, to compute the IR and Raman spectra, we need to compute the phonon Green's function. Going in Fourier space, we get

$$\begin{aligned} \chi_{\text{IR}\alpha}(\omega) &= \sum_{ij} \sum_{\beta\gamma} \frac{Z_{\alpha\beta}^i Z_{\alpha\gamma}^j}{\sqrt{m_i m_j}} \sqrt{m_i m_j} G_{\beta\gamma}^{ij}(\omega) \\ \chi_{\text{Raman}\alpha\beta}(\omega) &= \sum_{ij} \sum_{\gamma\delta} \frac{\Xi_{\alpha\beta\gamma}^i \Xi_{\alpha\beta\delta}^j}{\sqrt{m_i m_j}} \sqrt{m_i m_j} G_{\gamma\delta}^{ij}(\omega) \end{aligned}$$

6.2.1 The phonon Green's function

The phonon Green's function can be computed within the TD-SCHA. In general, we can write the Green's function as a non-interacting Green's function plus a self-energy:

$$G^{-1}(\omega) = G_0^{-1}(\omega) - \Pi(\omega)$$

where $G_0(\omega)$ is a non-interacting Green's function for *harmonic*-like phonons, while $\Pi(\omega)$ is the phonon self-energy, which depends on the frequency. In the TD-SCHA theory, the non-interacting Green's function is defined as the Green's function of the auxiliary SSCHA harmonic Hamiltonian.

$$G_0^{-1}(\omega) = I\omega^2 - D_{\text{SSCHA}}$$

where I is the identity matrix and D_{SSCHA} is the dynamical matrix of the SSCHA Hamiltonian.

The self-energy involves the third- and fourth-order interatomic force constants:

$$\Pi_{ab}(\omega) = -\frac{1}{2} \sum_{cd\mu\nu} \Phi_{acd}^{(3)} \Lambda_{\mu\nu}^{cd}(\omega) \left[1 + \frac{1}{2} \Phi \Lambda(\omega) \right]^{-1} \Phi_{\nu b}^{(3)}$$

This corresponds to the same expression derived for the Free energy Hessian; see [Bianco et al., Physical Review B, 96, 014111, 2017](#). where $\Lambda_{\mu\nu}^{cd}(\omega)$ is the Fourier transform of the two-phonon propagator, which can be computed from the equilibrium non interacting Green's function $G_0(\omega)$ as:

$$\Lambda_{\alpha\beta\gamma\delta}^{ijlm}(t) = \sqrt{m_i m_j m_l m_m} \langle \hat{u}_{\alpha}^i(t) \hat{u}_{\beta}^j(t) \hat{u}_{\gamma}^l(0) \hat{u}_{\delta}^m(0) \rangle_0$$

Computing the full inversion of the self-energy for every value of the frequency is computationally extremely expensive. It is possible, with an efficient algorithm (Lanczos), to show that the Green's function can be obtained by inverting a special matrix, see [Monacelli, Mauri, Physical Review B 103, 104305, 2021](#).

In this tutorial, we will use this Lanczos algorithm to compute the phonon Green's function and, consequently, the IR spectrum of CsPbI3.

To run these calculations, we need the `tdscha` package (it is recommended to configure it with the Julia speedup to run faster; see the installation guide).

6.3 Tutorial

We need to first relax a complete SSCHA calculation, exactly as for the free energy hessian. This can be performed via the `sscha_relax.py` script, which performs an automatic (fixed volume) sscha relaxation from the Harmonic dynamical matrix using 256 configurations.

We provide the final result already as `sscha_auxiliary_dyn_` files. The first step for a dynamical linear response calculation is to have a very well converged auxiliary dynamical matrix. For this purpose, it is useful to run an additional minimization with a higher number of configurations once the initial relaxation is done.

This is done by the script `last_sscha_minim.py` which we will analyze in the next section.

```
1 import sys, os
2 import cellconstructor as CC, cellconstructor.Phonons
3 import sscha, sscha.Ensemble, sscha.SchaMinimizer
4
5 from quippy.potential import Potential
6
7
8 TEMPERATURE = 450 # K
9 NQIRR = 4
10 START_DYN = "sscha_auxiliary_dyn_"
11 POTENTIAL = "../Materials/GAP_1.xml"
12 N_CONFIGS = 1024
13 POP_ID = 100
14
15
16 def last_sscha_relax(temperature = TEMPERATURE):
17     # Load the sscha dynamical matrix
18     dyn = CC.Phonons.Phonons(START_DYN, NQIRR)
19
20     # Load the interatomic Potential for CsPbI3
21     calc = Potential("IP GAP", param_filename=POTENTIAL)
22
23     # Generate the last ensemble
24     ensemble = sscha.Ensemble.Ensemble(dyn, temperature)
25     ensemble.generate(N_CONFIGS)
26
27     # Compute the energies and forces of the ensemble with the GAP potential
28     ensemble.compute_ensemble(calc)
29
30     # Compute a full sscha minimization on the new bigger ensemble
31     minim = sscha.SchaMinimizer.SSCHA_Minimizer(ensemble)
32     minim.set_minimization_step(0.02)
33     minim.meaningful_factor = 0.01
34     minim.run()
35
36     # Save the final dynamical matrix and ensemble for further calculations
37     minim.ensemble.save_bin("data", POP_ID)
38     minim.dyn.save_qe("sscha_converged_dyn_")
39
40
41 last_sscha_relax()
```

This script performs a full SSCHA minimization starting from the auxiliary dynamical matrix obtained from the previous SSCHA relaxation, but using a bigger ensemble of 1024 configurations. The final ensemble is saved in binary format inside the directory `data`, with a unique ID of 100 (any other ensemble with that ID will be overwritten). The final SSCHA auxiliary dynamical matrix is saved in the file `sscha_converged_dyn_`.

These are useful if you want to perform multiple linear response calculations, as they do not need to be recomputed.

Once we have the final converged auxiliary dynamical matrix, we can compute the phonon Green's function and the IR spectrum with the script `tdscha_run_ir.py`.

```

1 import cellconstructor as CC, cellconstructor.Phonons
2 import sscha, sscha.Ensemble
3 import numpy as np
4
5 import tdscha, tdscha.DynamicalLanczos
6
7 import sys, os
8
9 TEMPERATURE = 450 # K
10 NQIRR = 4 # Irreducible q points of the dynamical matrix
11
12 # Info about the dynamical matrix and the ensemble
13 ORIGINAL_DYN = "sscha_auxiliary_dyn_"
14 FINAL_DYN = "sscha_converged_dyn_"
15 POP_ID = 100
16
17 def compute_ir():
18     # Load the original ensemble
19     dyn_original = CC.Phonons.Phonons(ORIGINAL_DYN, NQIRR)
20     ensemble = sscha.Ensemble.Ensemble(dyn_original, TEMPERATURE)
21     ensemble.load_bin("data", POP_ID)
22
23     # Lets load the final converged dynamical matrix
24     final_dyn = CC.Phonons.Phonons(FINAL_DYN, NQIRR)
25
26     # To prepare the IR or Raman, we need
27     # IR : dielectric tensor and Born effective charges
28     # Raman : Raman tensor
29     # Load them from quantum espresso ph.x output
30     final_dyn.ReadInfoFromESPRESSO("dielectric_calc.pho")
31
32     # Update the ensemble weights on the converged dynamical matrix
33     ensemble.update_weights(final_dyn, TEMPERATURE)
34
35     # Initialize the TD-SCHA Lanczos algorithm
36     lanczos = tdscha.DynamicalLanczos.Lanczos(ensemble)
37     lanczos.init()
38
39     # Let us define which level of anharmonicity we want
40     lanczos.ignore_v3 = False # Add bubble contribution if false
41     lanczos.ignore_v4 = True # Add RPA resummation if false (a factor 2 slower in speed
42                             # - no extra memory)
43
44     # If both v3 and v4 are ignored (both true), we get the 'harmonic' spectrum
45     # on the sscha auxiliary frequencies
46
47     # Define the reponse function to observe
48     # In this case IR with polarization along the x axis
49     polarization = np.array([1.0, 0.0, 0.0])
50     lanczos.prepare_ir(pol_vec = polarization)
51
52     # Run the lanczos algorithm for 40 steps
53     lanczos.run_FT(40)

```

```

54     # Save the final result in binary
55     lanczos.save_status("IR_x.npz")
56
57
58 compute_ir()

```

6.3.1 Deep analysis of the script

Loading the ensemble

Let's analyze the script `tdscha_run_ir.py` step by step inside the function `compute_ir()`: The first step is loading the final sscha ensemble and dynamical matrix, which is achieved by the following lines:

```

1     dyn_original = CC.Phonons.Phonons(ORIGINAL_DYN, NQIRR)
2     ensemble = sscha.Ensemble.Ensemble(dyn_original, TEMPERATURE)
3     ensemble.load_bin("data", POP_ID)
4
5     # Lets load the final converged dynamical matrix
6     final_dyn = CC.Phonons.Phonons(FINAL_DYN, NQIRR)

```

Born effective charges and Raman tensors

Notably, we want to compute the IR response. For this reason, we need to tell the `tdscha` the relation between atomic displacements and the polarization. This is achieved by loading the Born effective charges and dielectric tensor from a Quantum ESPRESSO phonon calculation, which is done by the line:

```

1     final_dyn.ReadInfoFromESPRESSO("dielectric_calc.pho")

```

The file `dielectric_calc.pho` is the output of a Quantum ESPRESSO phonon calculation containing the Born effective charges and dielectric tensor. The input files used to generate this output are provided as `dielectric_calc.pwi` and `dielectric_calc.phi`. To write the `dielectric_calc.pwi` file, we first need to extract the structure from the final dynamical matrix, since the Born effective charges must be computed at the final converged centroid positions. This is performed by the file `extract_structure.py`, in particular by the lines:

```

1     # Load the final converged dynamical matrix
2     dyn = CC.Phonons.Phonons("sscha_converged_dyn_")
3
4     # Save the structure in the espresso format for pw.x
5     dyn.structure.save_scf("sscha_structure.scf")

```

The final structure looks like the following

```

1 CELL_PARAMETERS angstrom
2 6.2340501132548267 0.0000000000000000 0.0000000000000000
3 0.0000000000000000 6.2340501132548267 0.0000000000000000
4 0.0000000000000000 0.0000000000000000 6.2340501132548267
5
6 ATOMIC_POSITIONS angstrom
7 Cs 3.1170250566274138 3.1170250566274138 3.1170250566274138
8 Pb 0.0000000000000002 0.0000000000000002 0.0000000000000002
9 I 3.1170250566274138 0.0000000000000002 0.0000000000000002
10 I 0.0000000000000002 0.0000000000000002 3.1170250566274138
11 I 0.0000000000000002 3.1170250566274138 0.0000000000000002

```

This file contains the cell parameters (rows of the cell matrix) in Angstrom and the cartesian coordinates of all the atoms in the primitive cell (also in Angstrom). In this format, it can be pasted on the bottom of a Quantum ESPRESSO input file.

The two espresso inputs can be run with the following commands (**No need to do it now, it may take time, we already provide the final output files**):

```
1 mpirun -np 4 pw.x -npool 4 -i dielectric_calc.pwi > dielectric_calc.pwo
2 mpirun -np 4 ph.x -npool 4 -i dielectric_calc.phi > dielectric_calc.pho
```

Once the effective charges, Raman Tensor and Dielectric Tensor have been computed, they can be loaded in the final dynamical matrix with the method `ReadInfoFromESPRESSO`, which is used in the line:

```
1 final_dyn.ReadInfoFromESPRESSO("dielectric_calc.pho")
```

This is important if we want to compute IR or Raman response, as the response functions are computed with the effective charges and Raman tensor. We can skip this if, instead, we want just the displacement-displacement Green's function (e.g. to compute the free energy Hessian).

Update the ensemble

Next, we update the ensemble so that it reflects the final dynamical matrix, which is done by the line:

```
1 ensemble.update_weights(final_dyn, TEMPERATURE)
```

This is the reweighting, and it changes the weight of each stochastic configuration inside the ensemble so that, when we compute the average, we are computing the average with respect to the `final_dyn` rather than the dynamical matrix used to generate the ensemble. The new weights are computed as:

$$\rho_i = \frac{\rho_{\mathcal{R}_1, \Phi_1}(\mathbf{R}_i)}{\rho_{\mathcal{R}^{(0)}, \Phi^{(0)}}}$$

Initialize the Lanczos algorithm for dynamical linear response

Next, we need to prepare the grounds for the dynamical linear-response calculation. This is performed using the Lanczos algorithm. The algorithm is initialized as follows:

```
1 # Initialize the TD-SCHA Lanczos algorithm
2 lanczos = tdscha.DynamicalLanczos.Lanczos(ensemble)
3 lanczos.init()
4
5 # Let us define which level of anharmonicity we want
6 lanczos.ignore_v3 = False # Add bubble contribution if false
7 lanczos.ignore_v4 = True # Add RPA resummation if false
```

The `ignore_v3` and `ignore_v4` flags determine which approximation level we use to compute the phonon spectra. By setting both to False, we compute the full TD-SCHA response function without further approximations. Setting `ignore_v4` to True is equivalent to setting `include_v4` to False in the Free energy Hessian. However, thanks to how the Lanczos algorithm is formulated, including the full RPA resummation with the 4-phonon scattering vertices does not increase the computational cost of the algorithm. In particular, the cost only increases by a factor of 2, without any consequences on the memory. Here we ignore it for speed, but you can try setting it to False as well. This is also the reason why we can use the Lanczos algorithm from the TD-SCHA to compute the free energy Hessian accounting for the 4-phonon scatterings even in relatively large supercells without any memory issue.

Define the perturbation

Then, we need to specify which response function we want to compute. In this case IR response, with polarization along the x cartesian axis:

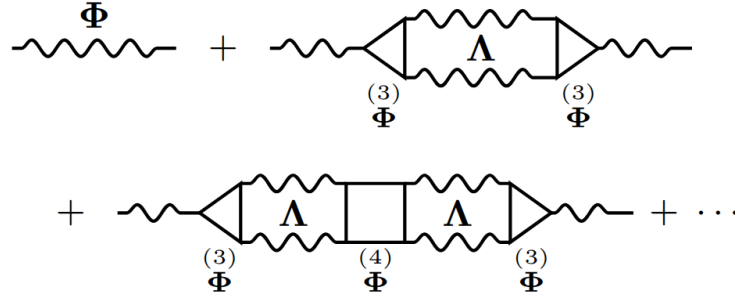


Figure 6.1: Diagrammatic series of perturbation present in the self-energy. The first term is the bare auxiliary harmonic propagation, the 3-phonon scattering vertex $\Phi^{(3)}$ enable the bubble diagram (the second term) while the 4-phonon scattering $\Phi^{(4)}$ enables all the chained diagrams obtained from the RPA like Dyson equation.

```

1  # Define the reponse function to observe
2  # In this case IR with polarization along the x axis
3  polarization = np.array([1.0, 0.0, 0.0])
4  lanczos.prepare_ir(pol_vec = polarization)

```

This call needs to know which atoms are displaced and by how much when we perturb the system with an electric field along the x axis. This information is contained in the effective charges, which are read from the `dielectric_calc.pho` file, therefore this call will crash if no effective charge is defined on the dynamical matrix. If we want to run the Raman, we would use the `prepare_raman` function instead, which needs the Raman tensor instead of the effective charges. Indeed, for the Raman, we need to pass both the input and output polarization vector for the electric field (scattering). If we wanted the displacement-displacement Green's function, there is no need to preload the effective charges or the Raman tensor. In this case, we just need to call `prepare_mode` passing the index of the phonon mode we want to perturb. The index of the phonon mode is ordered from 0 (the lowest frequency mode in the supercell) to $3N-3$ (the highest frequency mode in the supercell), excluding the 3 acoustic modes at Gamma.

Run the algorithm

Finally, we can run the Lanczos algorithm.

```

1  # Run the lanczos algorithm for 40 steps
2  lanczos.run_FT(40)

```

The Lanczos algorithm is iterative. We get to decide how many iterations. Feel free to reduce this to 20-30 iterations if it takes too much time. Each iteration computes the next Lanczos vector and the next element of the tridiagonal matrix, which is used to compute the response function. The more iterations we do, the better the resolution of the spectra. The run command takes multiples optional arguments. Let us see the API documentation for the `run_FT` method to see what we can do:

```

1  run_FT(n_iter, save_dir = None, save_each = 5, verbose = True, n_rep_ortho = 0,
        n_ortho = 10, flush_output = True, debug = False, prefix = "LANCZOS", run_simm
        = None, optimized = False)

```

Among these options, worth mentioning are `save_dir`, `save_each` and `prefix`. The `save_dir`, if set to something other than `None`, is the directory in which the intermediate status of the Lanczos algorithm is saved. This can be used to resume a previous calculation, or to check the convergence of the spectra with the number of iterations before we reached the maximum number of iterations. `save_each` is the number of iterations after which the status is saved, and `prefix` is the prefix of the filename in which the status is saved. By default,

the status is not saved, you can try to set `save_dir` to something like `'.'` to see that every 5 steps it will save a file with the name `LANCZOS_step_XX.npz`, where `XX` is the number of iterations.

We can also manually save at the end of the run with the method `save_status` of the Lanczos object, which takes as argument the filename in which the status is saved.

```
1 # Save the final result in binary
2 lanczos.save_status("IR_x.npz")
```

If we run the algorithm, we will get the final spectra in the file `IR_x.npz`.

6.3.2 Extract the green's function and plot

The TD-SCHA provides automatically a very simple way to plot the spectra with the command-line utility `tdscha-plot-data`

```
1 tdscha-plot-data IR_x.npz 0 200 0.5
```

The first argument is the file containing the Lanczos results. The next two arguments set the frequency range (in cm^{-1}), here from 0 to 200. The last argument is the smearing (in cm^{-1}) used to broaden the spectra. This command-line provides a quick way to plot the spectra. However, if you want more control, you can compute the spectrum directly in Python.

The example script that plots the spectrum is `plot_spectrum.py`.

```
1 import cellconstructor as CC, cellconstructor.Units
2 import tdscha, tdscha.DynamicalLanczos
3 import numpy as np
4 import matplotlib.pyplot as plt
5 import sys, os
6
7 DATA = "IR_x.npz"
8 W_START = 0 # cm-1
9 W_END = 200 # cm-1
10 TERMINATOR = True
11 SMEARING = 0.5 # cm-1
12
13 def plot_spectrum():
14     # Load the final lanczos results
15     lanczos = tdscha.DynamicalLanczos.Lanczos()
16     lanczos.load_status(DATA)
17
18     # Extract the Green function
19     w_array = np.linspace(W_START, W_END, 2000)
20     w_ry = w_array / CC.Units.RY_TO_CM
21     smearing_ry = SMEARING / CC.Units.RY_TO_CM
22     green_function = lanczos.get_green_function_continued_fraction(w_ry, smearing=
23                                     smearing_ry,
24                                     use_terminator =
25                                         TERMINATOR)
26
27     # The IR spectrum is proportional to - Im (G(w))
28     ir_spectrum = -np.imag(green_function)
29
30     # Plot the IR spectrum
31     plt.plot(w_array, ir_spectrum)
32     plt.xlabel("Frequency [cm-1]")
33     plt.ylabel("- Im (G)")
34     plt.title("IR spectrum - polarization x")
```

```

33 plt.tight_layout()
34 plt.savefig("ir_spectrum.png")
35 plt.show()
36
37
38 plot_spectrum()

```

The final result is plotted in the following figure

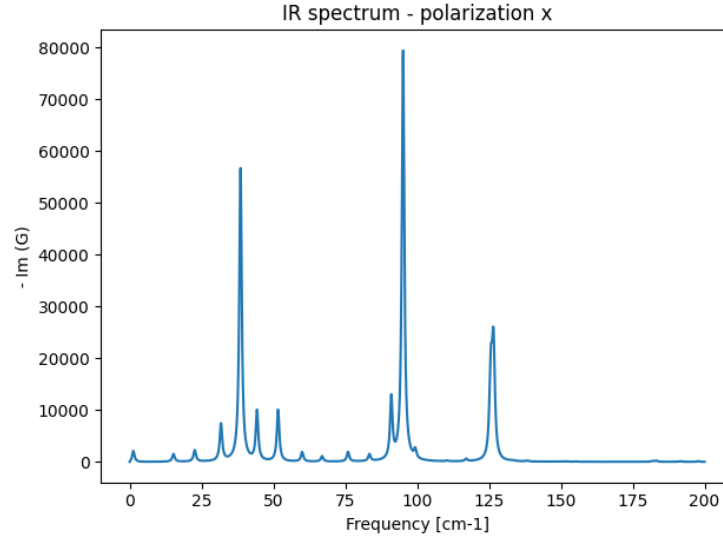


Figure 6.2: IR Spectrum obtained with the `plot_spectrum.py`.

The continued fraction

In particular, we first load the Lanczos algorithm status:

```

1 # Load the final lanczos results
2 lanczos = tdscha.DynamicalLanczos.Lanczos()
3 lanczos.load_status("IR_x.npz")

```

We then need to compute the Green's function from the Lanczos coefficient. The Lanczos algorithm finds an orthonormal basis in which the inverse-response function is a tridiagonal matrix $\mathcal{T}$

$$\mathcal{T} = \begin{pmatrix} a_1 & b_1 & 0 & 0 & \dots \\ b_1 & a_2 & b_2 & 0 & \dots \\ 0 & b_2 & a_3 & b_3 & \dots \\ 0 & 0 & b_3 & a_4 & \dots \\ \vdots & \vdots & \vdots & \vdots & \ddots \end{pmatrix}$$

where the first element of the basis is the perturbation vector. Therefore, the green function is actually the (1,1) element of the inverse of the tridiagonal matrix:

$$G(\omega + i\eta) = [\mathcal{T} - \mathcal{I}(\omega + i\eta)^2]_{1,1}^{-1}$$

where $\mathcal{I}$ is the identity matrix. Thanks to the many zeros in the tridiagonal matrix, the inverse of the first element is very easy to compute, and correspond to the following continued fraction:

$$G(\omega + i\eta) = \frac{1}{a_1 - (\omega + i\eta)^2 - \frac{b_1^2}{a_2 - (\omega + i\eta)^2 - \frac{b_2^2}{a_3 - (\omega + i\eta)^2 - \dots}}}$$

The function of the python script `get_green_function_continued_fraction` uses the `a_i`, `b_i` saved inside the `lanczos` object to compute the green function in the frequencies provided in input:

```
1 green_function = lanczos.get_green_function_continued_fraction(w_ry, smearing=
   smearing_ry,
2
                                     use_terminator =
                                     TERMINATOR)
```

This function takes as input the frequency `\omega` (in Ry units), the smearing `\eta`, and whether to use a *terminator*. The terminator is a trick to reach the `N\to\infty` limit (where `N` is the number of iterations). Empirically, we see that after a certain number of iterations, the coefficients `a_i` and `b_i` oscillate around a specific value. Therefore we can fill all the values for `i>N` with the average value of the coefficient, and simulate an infinite continued fraction. The infinite continued fraction can be solved analytically:

$$G_\infty(z) = \frac{1}{a_\infty - z^2 - b_\infty G_\infty(z)}$$

$$G_\infty(z) (a_\infty - z^2 - b_\infty G_\infty(z)) = 1$$

By solving this equation, we can replace the last fraction with the `G_\infty(z)`, simulating infinite iterations. Setting `use_terminator` to True truncates the continued fraction by replacing the tail with the asymptotic limit `G_\infty(z)`.

Exercise:

Compute the IR spectrum using the three different approximations: harmonic (SSCHA auxiliary frequencies), the bubble approximation (3-phonon only), and the full TD-SCHA (including 4-phonon scattering). Compare the results.

Question:

Is this calculation enough, or do we also need the response function for other perturbations, like `y` and `z`? Will something change in the spectrum if we do? Why?

Exercise:

Plot the IR data at various smearings and as a function of the number of steps (10, 20, 30, 40). How does the signal change with smearing and the number of steps? Try plotting with and without the terminator and see the differences.

6.4 Raman Response

The Raman response is very similar to the IR. Raman probes the fluctuations of the polarizability instead of those of the polarization, and it occurs when the sample interacts with two light sources: the incoming electromagnetic radiation and the outgoing one. The outgoing radiation has a frequency that is shifted with respect to the incoming one by the energy of the scattering phonons. The signal on the red side of the pump is called Stokes, while the signal on the blue side is the Anti-Stokes. Since the outgoing radiation has higher energy than the incoming one in the Anti-Stokes, it is generated only by existing (thermally excited) phonons inside the sample. As a result, the Anti-Stokes signal has a lower intensity than the Stokes.

Using the relation between polarizability and atomic displacements, the Raman intensity becomes:

$$I(\omega) \propto \sum_{ab} \frac{\Xi_{xya}\Xi_{xyb}}{\sqrt{m_a m_b}} [-\text{Im}G_{ab}(\omega)] (n(\omega) + 1)$$

where $G_{ab}(\omega)$ is the atomic Green's function on atoms a and b , while Ξ_{xya} is the Raman tensor along the electric fields directed in x and y on atom a .

The multiplication factor $n(\omega) + 1$ comes from the observation of the Stokes nonresonant Raman (it would be just $n(\omega)$ for the Anti-Stokes).

As we did for the IR signal, we can prepare the calculation of the Raman scattering by computing the polarizability-polarizability response function.

```

1 # Setup the polarized Raman response
2 polarization_in = np.array([1,0,0])
3 polarization_out = np.array([1,0,0])
4 lanczos.prepare_raman(pol_vec_in=polarization_in,
5                       pol_vec_out=polarization_out)

```

Note that here we have to specify two polarizations of the light: the incoming radiation and the outgoing radiation.

Indeed, we need the Raman tensor Ξ_{xya} defined within the dynamical matrix.

For the cubic phase, Ξ_{abc} is zero by symmetry, therefore there is no Raman active mode. To compute the Raman response, we need a lower symmetry phase.

In this case, we take the tetragonal (β) phase of CsPbI₃. We provide inside the **Materials** directory an already performed SSCHA relaxation at 300 K (`sscha_auxiliary_tetra_files`)

Also in this case, we need to perform a new final relaxation. This final relaxation can be performed with the `last_sscha_minim_tetra.py`, which is very similar to the script we employed for the cubic phase

```

1 import cellconstructor as CC, cellconstructor.Phonons
2 import sscha, sscha.Ensemble, sscha.SchaMinimizer
3
4 from quippy.potential import Potential
5
6
7 TEMPERATURE = 300 # K
8 NQIRR = 3
9 START_DYN = "sscha_auxiliary_tetra_"
10 POTENTIAL = "../Materials/GAP_1.xml"
11 N_CONFIGS = 1024
12 POP_ID = 200
13
14
15 def last_sscha_relax(temperature = TEMPERATURE):
16     # Load the sscha dynamical matrix
17     dyn = CC.Phonons.Phonons(START_DYN, NQIRR)
18
19     # Load the interatomic Potential for CsPbI3
20     calc = Potential("IP GAP", param_filename=POTENTIAL)
21
22     # Generate the last esemble
23     ensemble = sscha.Ensemble.Ensemble(dyn, temperature)
24     ensemble.generate(N_CONFIGS)
25
26     # Compute the energies and forces with the GAP potential

```

```

27 ensemble.compute_ensemble(calc)
28
29 # Compute a full sscha minimization on the new bigger ensemble
30 minim = sscha.SchaMinimizer.SSCHA_Minimizer(ensemble)
31 minim.set_minimization_step(0.02)
32 minim.meaningful_factor = 0.01
33 minim.run()
34
35 # Save the final dynamical matrix and ensemble for further calculations
36 minim.ensemble.save_bin("data", POP_ID)
37 minim.dyn.save_qe("sscha_converged_tetra_dyn_")
38
39 last_sscha_relax()
40

```

This script is very similar to the previous one, the main differences are: 1. The number of irreducible q-points NQIRR, which is 3 instead of 4 (we have a 2x2x1 supercell, so less q points in total) 2. The temperature is set to 300 K instead of 450 K 3. The name of the dynamical matrix is obviously different 4. We save the ensemble in population 200 to avoid overwriting the cubic one in population 100.

Once this script runs, we get the new ensemble and the final highly converged dynamical matrix. At this point, we need to compute the Raman tensor, using DFPT (e.g. using quantum espresso). The Raman tensor expresses how the polarizability changes when we move each atom. CellConstructor can load it from the quantum espresso ph.x output, like the Born effective charges.

The script to compute the Raman is:

```

1 import cellconstructor as CC, cellconstructor.Phonons
2 import sscha, sscha.Ensemble
3 import numpy as np
4
5 import tdscha, tdscha.DynamicalLanczos
6
7 import sys, os
8
9 TEMPERATURE = 300 # K
10 NQIRR = 3 # Irreducible q points of the dynamical matrix
11
12 # Info about the dynamical matrix and the ensemble
13 ORIGINAL_DYN = "sscha_auxiliary_tetra_"
14 FINAL_DYN = "sscha_converged_tetra_dyn_"
15 POP_ID = 200
16
17 def compute_raman():
18     # Load the original ensemble
19     dyn_original = CC.Phonons.Phonons(ORIGINAL_DYN, NQIRR)
20     ensemble = sscha.Ensemble.Ensemble(dyn_original, TEMPERATURE)
21     ensemble.load_bin("data", POP_ID)
22
23     # Lets load the final converged dynamical matrix
24     final_dyn = CC.Phonons.Phonons(FINAL_DYN, NQIRR)
25
26     # To prepare the Raman, we need to load the Raman tensor
27     # Load them from quantum espresso ph.x output
28     final_dyn.ReadInfoFromESPRESSO("dielectric_calc_tetra.pho")
29
30     # Update the ensemble weights on the converged dynamical matrix
31     ensemble.update_weights(final_dyn, TEMPERATURE)
32

```

```

33 # Initialize the TD-SCHA Lanczos algorithm
34 lanczos = tdscha.DynamicalLanczos.Lanczos(ensemble, lo_to_split = None)
35 lanczos.init()
36
37 # Let us define which level of anharmonicity we want
38 lanczos.ignore_v3 = False # Add bubble contribution if false
39 lanczos.ignore_v4 = True # Add RPA resummation if false (a factor 2 slower in speed
    - no extra memory)
40
41 # If both v3 and v4 are ignored (both true), we get the 'harmonic' spectrum
42 # on the sscha auxiliary frequencies
43
44 # Define the reponse function to observe
45 # In this case IR with polarization along the x axis
46 polarization_in = np.array([1.0, 0.0, 0.0])
47 polarization_out = np.array([1.0, 0.0, 0.0])
48 lanczos.prepare_raman(pol_vec_in = polarization_in,
49                       pol_vec_out = polarization_out
50                       )
51
52 # Run the lanczos algorithm for 40 steps
53 lanczos.run_FT(40)
54
55 # Save the final result in binary
56 lanczos.save_status("Raman_xx.npz")
57
58 if __name__ == "__main__":
59     # Change the working directory to the one containing this script
60     os.chdir(os.path.dirname(os.path.abspath(__file__)))
61     compute_raman()

```

Also this script is very similar to the IR one, with a few main differences:

1. We load the data of the tetragonal phase.
2. The Raman initialization

Let us focus on the Raman initialization:

```

1 # Define the reponse function to observe
2 # In this case IR with polarization along the x axis
3 polarization_in = np.array([1.0, 0.0, 0.0])
4 polarization_out = np.array([1.0, 0.0, 0.0])
5 lanczos.prepare_raman(pol_vec_in = polarization_in,
6                       pol_vec_out = polarization_out)

```

In this case, we need an incoming field polarization and an outgoing field polarization. The simultaneous presence of incoming and outgoing radiation generates a force on the atoms, which excites phonons inside the material.

The result is the following

Exercise:

Try to run the Raman off-diagonal like x-y, or the zz. Are the photo-excited modes the same?

The solution for the unpolarized Raman is something like

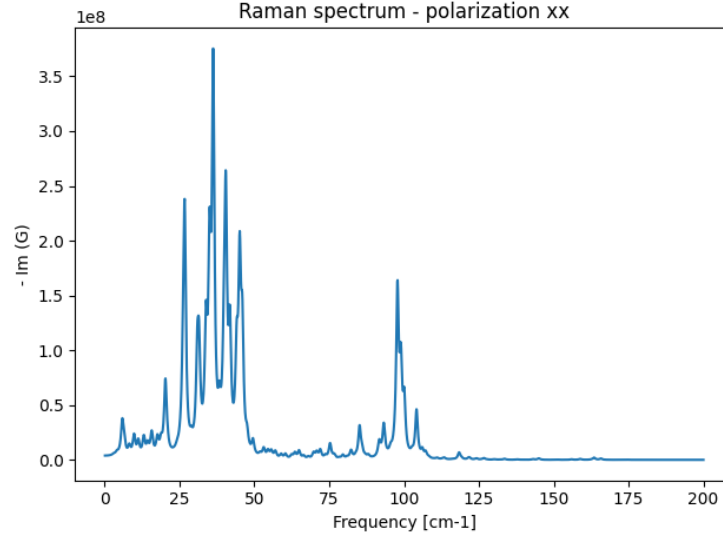


Figure 6.3: Raman spectrum with 200 iterations of the Lanczos algorithm along the x polarization for both incoming and outgoing radiation

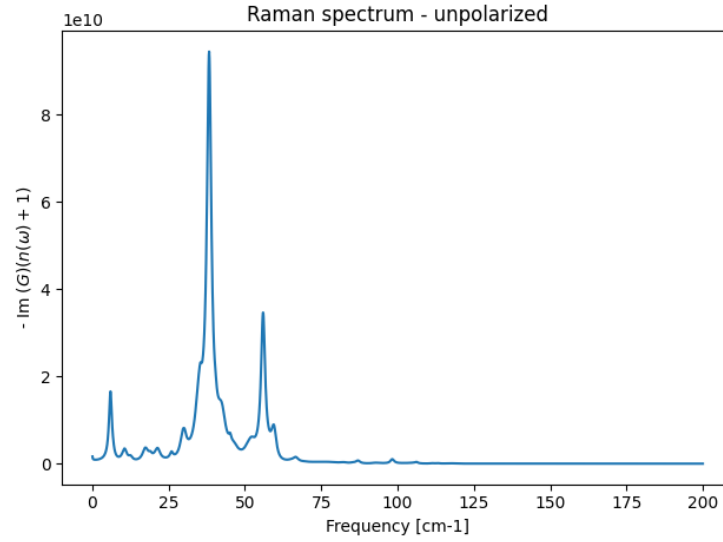


Figure 6.4: Unpolarized Raman. The scattering factor $n(\omega) + 1$ kills high frequency modes, which have a lower thermal population than low-frequency modes.

6.4.1 Unpolarized Raman

Often, experiments do not distinguish between laser polarization or sample orientation (e.g., the sample is a powder). In these cases, we need to average across all possible crystal orientation, or light polarization. This would require a Monte Carlo sampling, which could take a lot of computational time to compute the response function. An alternative approach is to directly compute the unpolarized Raman. In particular, the unpolarized Raman signal can be computed from the so-called *invariants*, where the perturbations in the polarizations are:

$$I_A = \frac{1}{9}(xx + yy + zz)^2$$

$$I_{B_1} = (xx - yy)^2/2$$

$$I_{B_2} = (xx - zz)^2/2$$

$$I_{B_3} = (yy - zz)^2/2$$

$$I_{B_4} = 3(xy)^2$$

$$I_{B_5} = 3(yz)^2$$

$$I_{B_6} = 3(xz)^2$$

The total intensity of unpolarized Raman is:

$$I_{\text{unpol}}(\omega) = 45 \cdot I_A(\omega) + 7 \cdot \sum_{i=1}^6 I_{B_i}(\omega)$$

The `tdscha` code implements a way to compute each perturbation separately. For example, the Raman response related to I_A is calculated with:

```
1 lanczos.prepare_raman(unpolarized=0)
```

While the I_{B_i} components are computed using index i . For example, to compute I_{B_5} :

```
1 # To compute I_B5 we do
2 lanczos.prepare_raman(unpolarized=5)
```

To obtain the total spectrum, you need to add the factor $n(\omega) + 1$ and sum all these perturbations with the correct prefactor (45 for I_A and 7 for the sum of all I_B).

To reset a calculation and start a new one, you can use:

```
1 lanczos.reset()
```

which may be called before preparing the perturbation.

This could be run inside a loop, e.g.

```

1 for i in range(7):
2     lanczos.prepare_raman( unpolarized=i)
3
4     # Run the lanczos algorithm for 40 steps
5     lanczos.run_FT(50)
6
7     # Save the final result in binary
8     lanczos.save_status(f"Raman_unpol{i}.npz")
9
10    # Reset the calculation, ready for a new perturbation
11    lanczos.reset()

```

Or, if the calculation is heavy, it could be run in parallel by simply running simultaneously the different perturbations.

Exercise:

Compute the unpolarized Raman spectrum of CsPbI₃ and plot the results.

Chapter 7

Hands-on Session 9: Thermal Conductivity Calculations with the SSCHA

In previous lessons, we saw how to calculate vibrational properties of materials using the stochastic self-consistent harmonic approximation (SSCHA). In this tutorial, we will use that knowledge to calculate the lattice thermal conductivity of materials.

To do this, we need the SSCHA dynamical matrices (**auxiliary dynamical matrices, not free-energy Hessians**) and the third-order force constants. These quantities allow us to calculate the harmonic properties, such as phonon frequencies and group velocities, and the anharmonic properties, such as phonon lifetimes and spectral functions. Together, these are the ingredients required for lattice thermal-conductivity calculations.

In this tutorial, we will:

- Use SSCHA dynamical matrices and third-order force constants to calculate lattice thermal conductivity with the Green-Kubo (GK) and single relaxation time approximation (SRTA) approaches.
- Learn how to converge lattice thermal-conductivity calculations.
- Manipulate `ThermalConductivity` objects to analyze the calculated transport properties.

The basic workflow is:

1. Relax the crystal structure and obtain SSCHA dynamical matrices in the temperature range of interest.
2. Use the relaxed SSCHA dynamical matrices to calculate the SSCHA free-energy Hessian, confirm dynamical stability, and obtain third-order force constants.
3. Calculate the lattice thermal conductivity and check its convergence with respect to:
 - the $\mathbf{q}$ -point grid used for the thermal-conductivity calculation;
 - the size of the SSCHA supercell;
 - the number of configurations used to calculate the third-order force constants;
 - the smearing parameter used in the phonon self-energy calculation, which is closely related to the size of the $\mathbf{q}$ -point grid when using an *adaptive* smearing scheme;
 - the density of frequency sampling controlled by the `ne` parameter when using the Green-Kubo method.

7.1 Lattice Thermal Conductivity of CsPbI₃

We first calculate the second- and third-order force constants.

```
1 import warnings
```

```

2
3 import ase
4 import ase.io
5 import numpy as np
6 from ase import Atoms
7 from ase.eos import calculate_eos
8 from ase.filters import ExpCellFilter
9 from ase.optimize import QuasiNewton
10 from ase.units import kJ
11 from quippy.potential import Potential
12
13 # Import the CellConstructor and SSCHA modules used throughout this tutorial.
14 import cellconstructor as CC
15 import cellconstructor.Phonons
16 import cellconstructor.Structure
17 import sscha
18 import sscha.Ensemble
19 import sscha.Relax
20 import sscha.SchaMinimizer
21
22 # NumPy moved ComplexWarning in newer versions. This block keeps the script
23 # compatible with both older and newer NumPy releases.
24 try:
25     ComplexWarning = np.exceptions.ComplexWarning
26 except AttributeError:
27     ComplexWarning = np.ComplexWarning
28
29 warnings.filterwarnings("ignore", category=ComplexWarning)
30
31
32 def get_starting_dynamical_matrices(structure_filename, potential, supercell):
33     """Relax the input structure and compute an initial dynamical matrix.
34
35     Parameters
36     -----
37     structure_filename : str
38         Path to the input structure in Quantum ESPRESSO format.
39     potential : quippy.potential.Potential
40         Interatomic potential used to compute energies and forces.
41     supercell : list[int]
42         Supercell used for the finite-displacement phonon calculation.
43
44     Returns
45     -----
46     dyn : cellconstructor.Phonons.Phonons
47         Initial auxiliary dynamical matrix.
48     bulk : float
49         Static bulk modulus, used during variable-cell SSCHA relaxation.
50     """
51     # Read the input structure with CellConstructor.
52     structure = CC.Structure.Structure()
53     structure.read_scf(structure_filename)
54
55     # Convert the CellConstructor structure to an ASE Atoms object so that
56     # ASE optimizers and the QUIP/GAP potential can be used.
57     atoms = Atoms(
58         cell=structure.unit_cell,
59         positions=structure.coords,
60         symbols=structure.atoms,

```

```

61         pbc=True,
62     )
63     atoms.set_calculator(potential)
64
65     # Relax both atomic positions and cell vectors.
66     ecf = ExpCellFilter(atoms)
67     qn = QuasiNewton(ecf)
68     qn.run(fmax=0.0005)
69
70     # Convert the relaxed ASE structure back to CellConstructor format.
71     structure = CC.Structure.Structure()
72     structure.generate_from_ase_atoms(atoms, get_masses=True)
73
74     # Compute an initial dynamical matrix by finite displacements.
75     dyn = CC.Phonons.compute_phonons_finite_displacements(
76         structure,
77         potential,
78         supercell=supercell,
79     )
80     dyn.Symmetrize()
81
82     # Remove imaginary frequencies from the starting guess. This produces a
83     # positive-definite auxiliary dynamical matrix for the SSCHA minimization.
84     dyn.ForcePositiveDefinite()
85
86     # Estimate the static bulk modulus from an equation-of-state fit. This is
87     # needed by the variable-cell SSCHA relaxation below.
88     eos = calculate_eos(atoms)
89     v0, e0, B = eos.fit()
90     bulk = B / kJ * 1.0e24
91
92     return dyn, bulk
93
94
95     # Input files and calculation settings. Adjust these paths for your machine.
96     src = "/scratch/ddangic/sscha_school_2026/Materials/"
97     structure_name = "CsPbI3_cubic_phase.scf"
98     pot = Potential(param_filename=src + "GAP_1.xml", calc_args="local_gap_variance")
99     supercell = [2, 2, 2]
100
101     # Generate the initial auxiliary dynamical matrix and the bulk modulus.
102     dyn, bulk = get_starting_dynamical_matrices(src + structure_name, pot, supercell)
103
104     # SSCHA relaxation settings.
105     temperature = 300.0
106     nconf = 500
107     max_pop = 1000
108
109     # Generate the initial SSCHA ensemble from the starting dynamical matrix.
110     ensemble = sscha.Ensemble.Ensemble(
111         dyn,
112         T0=temperature,
113         supercell=dyn.GetSupercell(),
114     )
115     ensemble.generate(N=nconf)
116
117     # Set up the SSCHA minimizer.
118     minimizer = sscha.SchaMinimizer.SSCHA_Minimizer(ensemble)
119     minimizer.min_step_dyn = 0.001

```

```

120 minimizer.kong_liu_ratio = 0.5
121 minimizer.meaningful_factor = 0.001
122 minimizer.max_ka = 100000
123
124 # Perform the variable-cell SSCHA relaxation.
125 relax = sscha.Relax.SSCHA(
126     minimizer,
127     ase_calculator=pot,
128     N_configs=nconf,
129     max_pop=max_pop,
130     save_ensemble=True,
131 )
132 relax.vc_relax(
133     static_bulk_modulus=bulk,
134     ensemble_loc="directory_of_the_ensemble",
135 )
136
137 # Recompute the SSCHA ensemble with an increasing number of configurations.
138 # This loop is used to test the convergence of the third-order force constants
139 # and the corresponding thermal-conductivity results.
140 for i in range(10):
141     numconf = (i + 1) * 1000
142
143     # Generate a new ensemble using the relaxed SSCHA dynamical matrix.
144     new_ensemble = sscha.Ensemble.Ensemble(
145         relax.minim.dyn,
146         T0=temperature,
147         supercell=relax.minim.dyn.GetSupercell(),
148     )
149     new_ensemble.generate(N=numconf)
150
151     # Compute energies, forces, and stresses for the generated configurations.
152     new_ensemble.compute_ensemble(
153         pot,
154         compute_stress=True,
155         stress_numerical=False,
156         cluster=None,
157         verbose=True,
158     )
159
160     # Minimize the free energy for the new ensemble. We keep the structure fixed
161     # here because the variable-cell relaxation was already performed above.
162     new_minimizer = sscha.SchaMinimizer.SSCHA_Minimizer(new_ensemble)
163     new_minimizer.minim_struct = False
164     new_minimizer.set_minimization_step(0.001)
165     new_minimizer.meaningful_factor = 0.001
166     new_minimizer.max_ka = 10000
167     new_minimizer.init()
168     new_minimizer.run()
169
170     # Save the converged auxiliary dynamical matrix in Quantum ESPRESSO format.
171     new_minimizer.dyn.save_qe("final_dyn_" + str(numconf) + ".")
172
173     # Reweight the ensemble with the updated dynamical matrix.
174     new_ensemble.update_weights(new_minimizer.dyn, temperature)
175
176     # Calculate the free-energy Hessian and the third-order tensor.
177     # Setting return_d3=True returns the third-order force constants needed for
178     # the thermal-conductivity calculation.

```

```

179     dyn_hessian, d3_tensor = new_ensemble.get_free_energy_hessian(
180         include_v4=False,
181         get_full_hessian=True,
182         return_d3=True,
183     )
184
185     # Save the third-order tensor and the Hessian for later use.
186     np.save("d3_" + str(numconf) + ".npz", d3_tensor)
187     dyn_hessian.save_qe("hessian_dyn_" + str(numconf) + ".")

```

In this example, we used a $2 \times 2 \times 2$ supercell to calculate the second- and third-order force constants. The third-order force constants were calculated using an increasing number of configurations in order to test the convergence of the ensemble average.

The second- and third-order force constants must be converged with respect to both the supercell size and the number of configurations. Figure 1 shows the results for harmonic properties. The phonon band structure interpolated from the $2 \times 2 \times 2$ supercell is converged with respect to the number of configurations at around 2000 configurations. However, the results also need to be converged with respect to the supercell size, and they do not appear to be converged even for the $4 \times 4 \times 4$ supercell.

Figure 1. Convergence study of the phonon band structure with respect to supercell size and the number of configurations.

First, we calculate the lattice thermal conductivity using the single relaxation time approximation (**SRTA**). In this approximation, the thermal-conductivity tensor is written as

```

1  \kappa^{\{xy\}}
2  =
3  \frac{1}{N V}
4  \sum_{\mathbf{q}, j}
5  v^x_{\mathbf{q}, j} v^y_{\mathbf{q}, j}
6  c_{\mathbf{q}, j}
7  \tau_{\mathbf{q}, j}.
8

```

Here, N is the number of $\mathbf{q}$ points, V is the unit-cell volume, $v^x_{\mathbf{q}, j}$ and $v^y_{\mathbf{q}, j}$ are the phonon group-velocity components, $c_{\mathbf{q}, j}$ is the mode heat capacity, and $\tau_{\mathbf{q}, j}$ is the phonon lifetime for phonon mode j at wave vector $\mathbf{q}$. To calculate the thermal conductivity using force constants obtained with different numbers of configurations, we can use the following script:

```

1  from __future__ import division, print_function
2
3  import time
4
5  import numpy as np
6
7  import cellconstructor as CC
8  import cellconstructor.ForceTensor
9  import cellconstructor.Phonons
10 import cellconstructor.ThermalConductivity
11
12 # Number of irreducible q points/files in the saved dynamical matrix.
13 nqirr = 4
14
15 # Useful conversion factors from CellConstructor.
16 SSCHA_TO_MS = cellconstructor.ThermalConductivity.SSCHA_TO_MS
17 RY_TO_THZ = cellconstructor.ThermalConductivity.SSCHA_TO_THZ
18
19 # Use the same grid for phonon properties and scattering processes in this

```



```

20 # example. In production calculations, these two grids should be converged
21 # separately.
22 meshnum = 10
23 mesh = [meshnum, meshnum, meshnum]
24
25 # Loop over force constants obtained from different ensemble sizes. This starts
26 # from 2000 configurations because range(1, 10) gives i = 1, ..., 9.
27 for i in range(1, 10):
28     numconf = (i + 1) * 1000
29
30     # Read the auxiliary SSCHA dynamical matrix saved in the previous step.
31     dyn_prefix = "final_dyn_" + str(numconf) + "_"
32     dyn = CC.Phonons.Phonons(dyn_prefix, nqirr)
33     supercell = dyn.GetSupercell()
34
35     # Create the third-order force-constant object using the same supercell
36     # used to generate the SSCHA dynamical matrix.
37     fc3 = CC.ForceTensor.Tensor3(
38         dyn.structure,
39         dyn.structure.generate_supercell(supercell),
40         supercell,
41     )
42
43     # Load the third-order tensor and use it to initialize fc3.
44     d3_name = "d3_" + str(numconf) + ".npz"
45     d3 = np.load(d3_name)
46     fc3.SetupFromTensor(d3)
47
48     # Center the third-order force constants. This step is necessary
49     # in order to interpolate 3rd order force constants.
50     fc3 = CC.ThermalConductivity.centering_fc3(fc3)
51
52     # Define the ThermalConductivity object. The kpoint_grid is the grid on which
53     # phonon quantities are calculated on, while scattering_grid controls
54     # the sampling of scattering processes.
55     tc = CC.ThermalConductivity.ThermalConductivity(
56         dyn,
57         fc3,
58         kpoint_grid=mesh,
59         scattering_grid=mesh,
60         smearing_scale=None,
61         smearing_type="adaptive",
62         cp_mode="quantum",
63         off_diag=True,
64     )
65
66     # Calculate the thermal conductivity at 300 K.
67     temperatures = np.linspace(300, 300, 1, dtype=float)
68     start_time = time.time()
69
70     # Compute harmonic quantities such as phonon frequencies and group
71     # velocities, then write them to text files.
72     tc.setup_harmonic_properties()
73     tc.write_harmonic_properties_to_file()
74
75     # Calculate the lattice thermal conductivity in the SRTA approximation.
76     # Lifetimes are written to file because write_lifetimes=True.
77     tc.calculate_kappa(
78         mode="SRTA",

```

```

79     temperatures=temperatures,
80     write_lifetimes=True,
81     gauss_smearing=True,
82     offdiag_mode="perturbative",
83     kappa_filename="ConfThermal_conductivity_SRTA_" + str(numconf),
84     lf_method="fortran-LA",
85 )

```

The most important parts of the script are:

- The mesh used to calculate phonon properties is defined to be the same as the mesh used to calculate scattering processes. This is controlled by the variable `mesh`. These grids do not have to be identical. In many cases, `scattering_grid` can be much smaller than `kpoint_grid`. **Both grids must be converged.**
- We use a smearing approach to satisfy energy-conservation laws. There are two methods: constant and adaptive. For `smearing_type = "constant"`, the smearing value must be provided in `Ry` as an argument to `setup_harmonic_properties`. For adaptive smearing, as used here, the smearing value is different for different phonon modes and is based on the phonon density of states and `q`-point grid density. A global scaling factor can still be provided through `smearing_scale`; `smearing_scale = 1.0` often works well. **The smearing parameters must also be converged.**
- The `off_diag` variable controls whether the calculation includes what is often called *coherent transport*. This contribution can be important for strongly anharmonic materials with significant bunching of phonon modes.
- The function `calculate_kappa` performs most of the transport calculation. Its main options are:
 - `mode` defines the method used to calculate the lattice thermal conductivity. The options are **SRTA**, which corresponds to the Boltzmann transport equation in the single relaxation time approximation, and **GK** (Dangic et al.), which is the Green-Kubo method based on phonon spectral functions rather than phonon lifetimes. These two modes should give similar results in weakly anharmonic materials, but they can differ in strongly anharmonic materials.
 - `gauss_smearing` defines how energy conservation is treated in the self-energy calculation. If `True`, Gaussian functions are used. If `False`, Lorentzian functions are used. With Gaussian smearing, the real part of the self-energy is calculated using the Kramers-Kronig transformation.
 - `offdiag_mode` defines how coherent transport is calculated when `mode = "SRTA"`. The available options are **wigner** (Simoncelli et al.), **gk** (Isaeva et al.), and **perturbative** (Dangic et al.). If `mode = "GK"`, coherent transport is included naturally.
 - `lf_method` defines how phonon lifetimes are calculated when `mode = "SRTA"`. In most cases, keep the `fortran-` prefix and add either `LA` or `P`; these options should give similar results. Another option is `SC`, where phonon lifetimes are solved self-consistently and phonon lineshifts are included.
 - `ne` defines the number of frequency steps used when calculating phonon lineshapes. It is also important for `lf_method = "SC"`, because the self-consistent equation is solved on a frequency grid and the real and imaginary parts of the self-energy are linearly interpolated. Larger values are generally more accurate. **The results must be converged with respect to `ne`.**

In this example, we use the *SRTA* approximation, which is the weak-anharmonicity limit of the Green-Kubo equation. We use SSCHA auxiliary dynamical matrices because they form the basis for the dynamical extension of the SSCHA, derived from time-dependent SSCHA, which gives access to phonon lifetimes and lineshapes.

By setting `off_diag=True`, we include the coherent contribution to the lattice thermal conductivity. This contribution is important in strongly anharmonic materials, alloys, and amorphous solids. The calculation should take a few minutes, and the results are saved using the filename prefix specified by `kappa_filename`.

The thermal conductivity should also be calculated using different `q`-point grids. Figure 2 includes results obtained for a $3 \times 3 \times 3$ grid. These calculations do not appear to be converged at the $3 \times 3 \times 3$ level, so a larger supercell would be required for a production calculation.

However, third-order force constants often converge faster with respect to supercell size than second-order force constants. Therefore, one can sometimes combine dynamical matrices computed on a larger supercell

with third-order force constants computed on a smaller supercell. This approach is illustrated in the script below:

```

1  from __future__ import print_function
2  from __future__ import division
3
4  import time
5
6  import numpy as np
7  import cellconstructor as CC
8  import cellconstructor.Phonons
9  import cellconstructor.ForceTensor
10 import cellconstructor.ThermalConductivity
11
12 SSCHA_TO_MS = cellconstructor.ThermalConductivity.SSCHA_TO_MS
13 RY_TO_THZ = cellconstructor.ThermalConductivity.SSCHA_TO_THZ
14
15 # Define the q-point grid used for both harmonic properties and scattering processes.
16 meshnum = 10
17 mesh = [meshnum, meshnum, meshnum]
18
19 # Define the temperature at which the thermal conductivity will be calculated.
20 temperatures = np.linspace(300, 300, 1, dtype=float)
21
22 # Read the dynamical matrix corresponding to the same supercell used to compute
23 # the third-order force constants.
24 dyn_prefix = "final_dyn_2x2x2_"
25 nqirr = 4
26 dyn_for_fc3 = CC.Phonons.Phonons(dyn_prefix, nqirr)
27
28 # Initialize and load the third-order force-constant tensor.
29 supercell = dyn_for_fc3.GetSupercell()
30 fc3 = CC.ForceTensor.Tensor3(
31     dyn_for_fc3.structure,
32     dyn_for_fc3.structure.generate_supercell(supercell),
33     supercell,
34 )
35
36 d3_name = "d3_2x2x2.npy"
37 d3 = np.load(d3_name)
38 fc3.SetupFromTensor(d3)
39
40 # Center the third-order force constants.
41 fc3 = CC.ThermalConductivity.centering_fc3(fc3)
42
43 # Read a dynamical matrix computed using a larger supercell.
44 # This matrix will provide the harmonic properties used in the transport calculation.
45 dyn_prefix = "./final_dyn_4x4x4_"
46 nqirr = 10
47 dyn = CC.Phonons.Phonons(dyn_prefix, nqirr)
48
49 # Build the ThermalConductivity object using the large-supercell dynamical matrix
50 # and the small-supercell third-order force constants.
51 tc = CC.ThermalConductivity.ThermalConductivity(
52     dyn,
53     fc3,
54     kpoint_grid=mesh,
55     scattering_grid=mesh,
56     smearing_scale=None,

```

```

57     smearing_type="adaptive",
58     cp_mode="quantum",
59     off_diag=True,
60 )
61
62 start_time = time.time()
63
64 # Compute harmonic properties and write them to file.
65 tc.setup_harmonic_properties()
66 tc.write_harmonic_properties_to_file()
67
68 # Calculate the thermal conductivity in the SRTA approximation.
69 tc.calculate_kappa(
70     mode="SRTA",
71     temperatures=temperatures,
72     write_lifetimes=True,
73     gauss_smearing=True,
74     offdiag_mode="perturbative",
75     kappa_filename="Thermal_conductivity_SRTA",
76     lf_method="fortran-LA",
77 )

```

Figure 2. Convergence study of thermal conductivity with respect to q-point sampling, supercell size, and number of configurations.

Finally, we can calculate the lattice thermal conductivity with the Green-Kubo method:

$$\kappa_{xy} = \frac{2\pi\beta}{NV} \sum_{\mathbf{q},j,j'} v^x_{\mathbf{q},j} v^y_{\mathbf{q},j'} \omega_{\mathbf{q},j} \omega_{\mathbf{q},j'} \int_{-\infty}^{\infty} \langle \mathbf{v}(\mathbf{q},j) \cdot \mathbf{v}(\mathbf{q},j') \rangle \exp(i\omega_{\mathbf{q},j} \tau) \exp(i\omega_{\mathbf{q},j'} \tau) d\tau$$

Here the $\sigma_{\mathbf{q},j}$ is phonon spectral function. The python script that does the calculation is:

```

1  from __future__ import division, print_function
2
3  import time
4
5  import numpy as np
6
7  import cellconstructor as CC
8  import cellconstructor.ForceTensor
9  import cellconstructor.Phonons
10 import cellconstructor.ThermalConductivity
11
12 # Use the dynamical matrix and third-order force constants obtained with
13 # 10000 configurations.
14 dyn_prefix = "final_dyn_10000_"
15 nqirr = 4
16
17 # Useful conversion factors.
18 SSCHA_TO_MS = cellconstructor.ThermalConductivity.SSCHA_TO_MS
19 RY_TO_THZ = cellconstructor.ThermalConductivity.SSCHA_TO_THZ
20
21 # Read the auxiliary SSCHA dynamical matrix.
22 dyn = CC.Phonons.Phonons(dyn_prefix, nqirr)
23 supercell = dyn.GetSupercell()
24

```

```

25 # Build and initialize the third-order force-constant tensor.
26 fc3 = CC.ForceTensor.Tensor3(
27     dyn.structure,
28     dyn.structure.generate_supercell(supercell),
29     supercell,
30 )
31 d3 = np.load("d3_10000.npy")
32 fc3.SetupFromTensor(d3)
33 fc3 = CC.ThermalConductivity.centering_fc3(fc3)
34
35 # Define the q-point grid for the Green-Kubo calculation.
36 meshnum = 10
37 mesh = [meshnum, meshnum, meshnum]
38
39 # Set up the ThermalConductivity object. With mode="GK", the method uses
40 # phonon spectral functions rather than phonon lifetimes.
41 tc = CC.ThermalConductivity.ThermalConductivity(
42     dyn,
43     fc3,
44     kpoint_grid=mesh,
45     scattering_grid=mesh,
46     smearing_scale=1.0,
47     smearing_type="adaptive",
48     cp_mode="quantum",
49     off_diag=True,
50 )
51
52 # Compute harmonic quantities once. They are reused for all values of ne below.
53 temperatures = np.linspace(300, 300, 1, dtype=float)
54 start_time = time.time()
55 tc.setup_harmonic_properties()
56 tc.write_harmonic_properties_to_file()
57
58 # Converge the Green-Kubo calculation with respect to the number of frequency
59 # points used to integrate overlaps of phonon spectral functions.
60 for i in range(5):
61     ne = i * 2000 + 1000
62
63     tc.calculate_kappa(
64         mode="GK",
65         temperatures=temperatures,
66         write_lifetimes=False,
67         gauss_smearing=False,
68         ne=ne,
69         offdiag_mode="perturbative",
70         kappa_filename="Thermal_conductivity_GK_" + str(ne),
71         lf_method="fortran-LA",
72     )
73
74 # Save the ThermalConductivity object for post-processing.
75 tc.save_pickle()

```

The Green-Kubo calculation introduces an additional convergence parameter: the number of frequency points used to integrate the overlap of phonon spectral functions. The frequency spacing is approximately $2.1\omega_D/n_e$, where ω_D is the highest frequency on the $\mathbf{q}$ -point grid. For an accurate estimate of the integrals, this frequency spacing should be smaller than the smallest phonon linewidth. Therefore, materials with higher thermal conductivity will likely require larger values of n_e .

The SRTA and GK methods usually agree well for weakly anharmonic materials. For strongly anharmonic

materials, however, their results can differ significantly.

The final line of the previous script saves the `ThermalConductivity` object, which can later be used to analyze the calculated transport quantities. The snippet below reloads this object and writes the phonon spectral function at Γ :

```
1 from __future__ import division, print_function
2
3 import time
4
5 import matplotlib.gridspec as gridspec
6 import matplotlib.pyplot as plt
7 import numpy as np
8
9 import cellconstructor as CC
10 import cellconstructor.ForceTensor
11 import cellconstructor.Phonons
12 import cellconstructor.ThermalConductivity
13
14 # Reload the ThermalConductivity object saved with tc.save_pickle().
15 tc = CC.ThermalConductivity.load_thermal_conductivity()
16
17 # Temperature-dependent quantities, such as lineshapes, are stored in
18 # dictionaries. The keys are strings formatted as format(T, ".1f").
19 keys = list(tc.lineshapes.keys())
20
21 # Find the Gamma point in the q-point grid.
22 for iqpt in range(tc.nkpt):
23     if np.linalg.norm(tc.k_points[iqpt]) == 0.0:
24         break
25
26 # Build the frequency grid associated with the saved lineshape data.
27 energies = (
28     np.arange(len(tc.lineshapes[keys[-1]] [0, 0]), dtype=float) * tc.delta_omega
29     + tc.delta_omega
30 )
31
32 # Write the phonon spectral function at Gamma to a text file.
33 tc.write_lineshape(
34     "Lineshape_at_Gamma",
35     tc.lineshapes[keys[-1]] [iqpt],
36     iqpt,
37     energies,
38     "no",
39 )
```

Temperature-dependent transport properties, such as phonon lifetimes, heat capacities, and phonon lineshapes, are stored as dictionaries with keys corresponding to the temperature T formatted as `format(T, ".1f")`. The example above writes the phonon spectral function at Γ .

Other relevant quantities, such as phonon frequencies and group velocities, can also be accessed from the `ThermalConductivity` object. In addition, the object provides built-in functions for calculating the phonon density of states, phonon spectral conductivity, and phonon Grüneisen parameters in cubic systems

7.2 Exercise

Estimate the lattice thermal conductivity of CsPbI_3 in the cubic $Pm\bar{3}m$ phase.

Before computing the thermal conductivity, first check the dynamical stability of this phase. In particular, determine the temperature range in which the cubic phase is dynamically stable and therefore the thermal-conductivity calculation is physically meaningful.

Then compare the lattice thermal conductivity obtained using:

- the single relaxation time approximation (**SRTA**), and
- the Green-Kubo (**GK**) approach.

Discuss the following points:

1. At what temperature does the cubic $Pm\bar{3}m$ phase become dynamically stable?
2. How does the thermal conductivity depend on temperature?
3. Do the SRTA and GK results agree? If not, which method gives a larger thermal conductivity and why?
4. What does the comparison between SRTA and GK tell you about the degree of anharmonicity in cubic CsPbI₃?

Chapter 8

Hands-on-session 5: EPIq - Anharmonicity in electron-phonon coupling related properties

8.1 Introduction

In this hands-on session we learn how to include anharmonic effects calculated within the SSCHA in the calculation of electron-phonon coupling related properties using [EPIq](#).

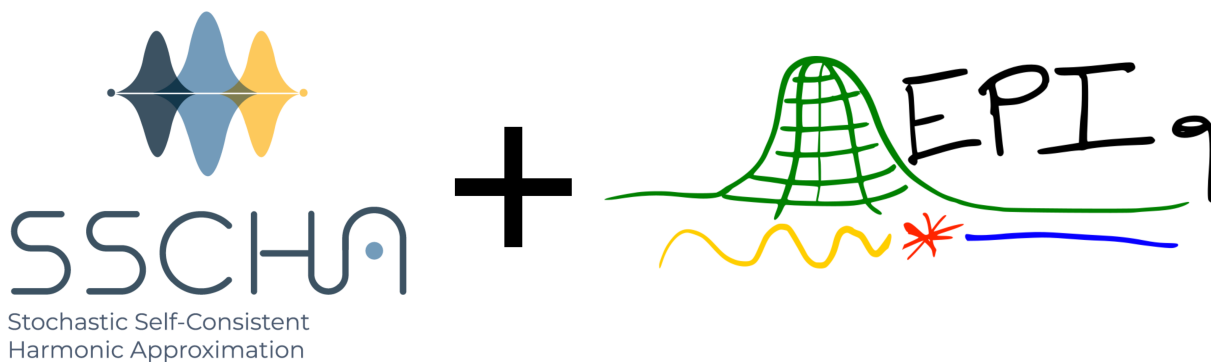


Figure 8.1: logo_epiq

In some systems the first principles calculation of electron-phonon coupling matrix elements can be demanding. EPIq (Electron-Phonon wannier Interpolation over k and q-points) is an open-source software that allows to speed up the calculation of electron-phonon coupling related properties using the Wannier interpolation technique. Details on the interpolation scheme can be found [here](#). Within EPIq, it is possible to include anharmonic corrections to the dynamical matrices as calculated within the SSCHA.

8.2 Requirements

In the interest of time, in this hands-on session the following starting data are at your disposal:

1. Electron-phonon matrix elements $g_{m,n}^\nu(\mathbf{k}, \mathbf{q})$ computed from first principles.
2. Wannier interpolation files which encode the transformation to the optimally smooth subspace, $U_{mn} : |\mathbf{R}n\rangle = \frac{1}{\sqrt{N_k^w}} \sum_{\mathbf{k}=1}^{N_k^w} \sum_{m=1}^{N_w} e^{-i\mathbf{k}\cdot\mathbf{R}} U_{mn}(\mathbf{k}) |\psi_{\mathbf{k}m}\rangle$
3. Anharmonic dynamical matrices $D_{\mu,\nu}^{SCHA}(\mathbf{k}, \mathbf{q})$.
4. Harmonic dynamical matrices (as a reference) $D_{\mu,\nu}^{HARM}(\mathbf{k}, \mathbf{q})$.

Attention

A folder prepared for you with these data for the present tutorial can be downloaded in the **Materials/tutorial_05** folder in the sscha school 2026 github repository. The folder contains

1. The electron-phonon coupling matrix elements can be found in the **mat_elem** folder. Each file corresponds to a different **q**-point in the first Brillouin zone.
2. The **Wannier** folder contains the files (**.eig**, **.chk**).
3. The dynamical matrices are stored in the **dyn_mat** directory. **dynq*** files are harmonic ($D_{\mu,\nu}^{HARM}(\mathbf{k}, \mathbf{q})$) while **MoS2.Hessian.dyn*** are anharmonic dynamical matrices computed with the SSCHA code ($D_{\mu,\nu}^{SCHA}(\mathbf{k}, \mathbf{q})$).

Place all the downloaded material where you intend to run the tutorial.

8.2.1 Download EPIq

First, deactivate the conda environment if it is active, typing **conda deactivate**. To download epiq, enter the folder where you want to install epiq in your virtual machine and type on the command line

```
1 git clone --depth 1 --branch develop https://gitlab.com/the-epiq-team/epiq.git
```

then, enter the just created with **cd epiq** and install it typing the following command

```
1 ./configure && make all CC="gcc -std=gnu89"
```

all the executables (.x files) will be installed in epiq/bin.

8.3 About EPIq

Epiq site: <https://the-epiq-team.gitlab.io/epiq-site/>

Epiq paper: <https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S0010465523002953>

The [Electron-Phonon Interpolation over q and k points] package exploits Wannier interpolation to obtain many proprieties in solids. Bloch theorem allows to describe an infinite system in real space with a continuum of Hamiltonian for different k-points in the Brillouin zone.

The properties of a material refers to a certain observable averaged over the sample. Thanks to the Bloch theorem it is often convenient to perform the average in the reciprocal k-space. In other words as a sum over the whole Brillouin zone of the quantities defined at each k-point.

$$\langle O \rangle = \frac{1}{N_k} \sum_{\mathbf{k}} F_O(\mathbf{k})$$

The quality of the averaging depends on the finesse of the sampling N_k and of the smoothness of the integrand function $F_O(\mathbf{k})$ (a constant function is totally described with just one k-point).

Wannier interpolation is an efficient way to refined the Brillouin zone sampling.

8.3.1 Calculations available in EPIq

1. Adiabatic (static) and non-adiabatic (dynamic) force constant matrices.
2. **Electron-phonon contribution to the phonon linewidth** and related quantities.
3. Isotropic and **anisotropic Eliashberg equations**.

Why metallic systems are difficult

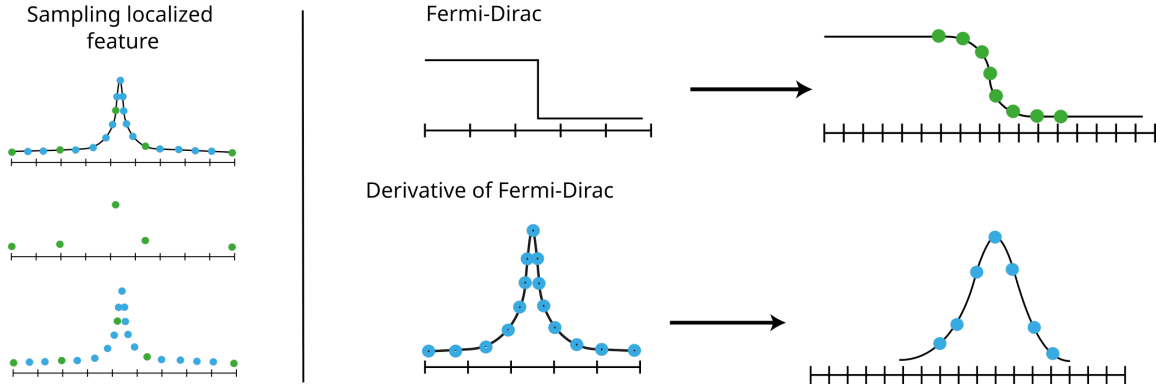


Figure 8.2: sampling

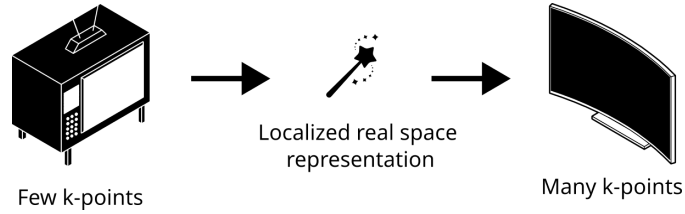


Figure 8.3: wannier_interpolation

4. Double Resonant Raman scattering.
5. Electron lifetime and relaxation time.

8.3.2 EPIq workflow

The core steps of any calculation employing EPIq are performed using the main executable `epiq.x` and consists in two main stages.

1. A preliminary step where electron-phonon coupling matrix elements and the Hamiltonian are Fourier-transformed to real space and written to file.
2. The electron-phonon coupling matrix elements and the Hamiltonian are transformed back to reciprocal space to compute the property of interest at arbitrary k - and q - values.

8.3.3 EPIq input file

The input file is divided in three namelists:

1. `$control`, specifying what calculation the code will perform
2. `**&electrons*`, specifying the electronic parameters of the property to be computed
3. `$phonons`, specifying the phonons parameters for the property to be computed

Finally, the last lines of the input indicates the electron momentum (k -) and phonon momentum (q -) meshes on which the matrix elements are interpolated to.

8.4 Setup phase: how to setup a calculation with EPIq

In this tutorial we calculate electron-phonon coupling related properties for doped monolayer MoS_2 , and evaluate the effect of anharmonicity on them.

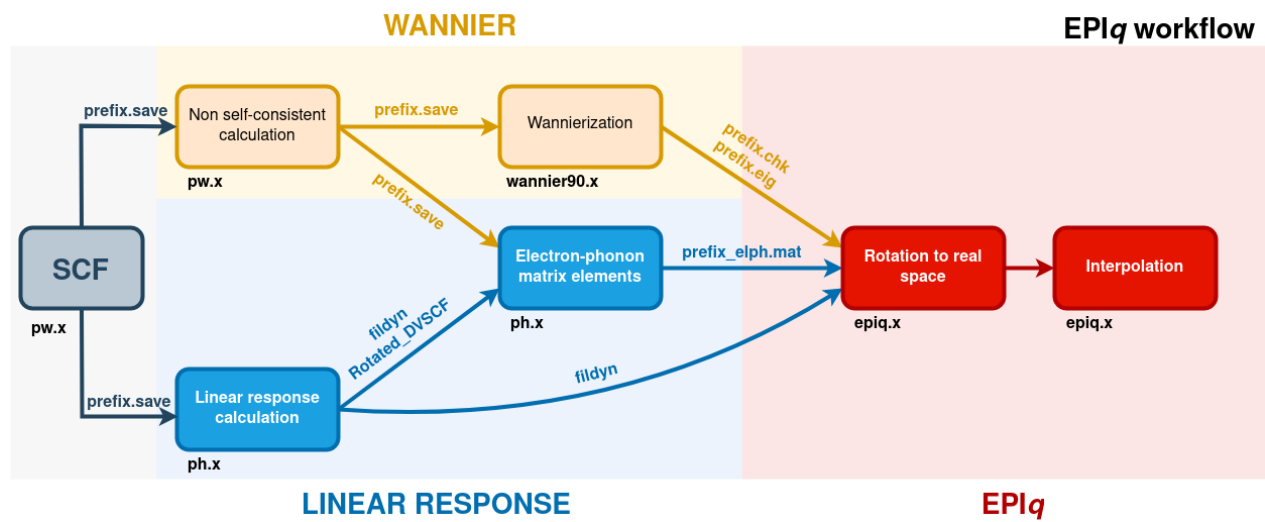


Figure 8.4: wannier

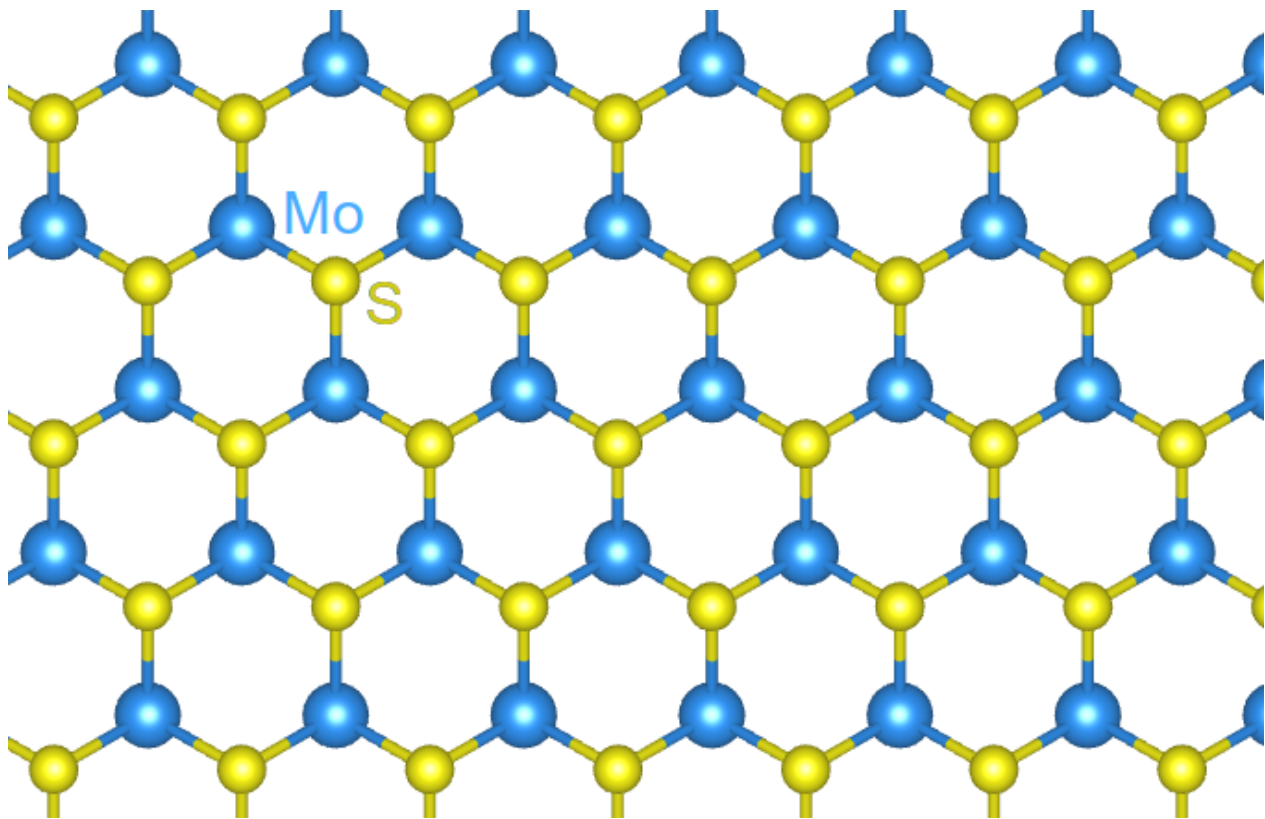


Figure 8.5: wannier

8.4.1 Wannier interpolation

As explained in the previous section, any calculation within EPIq starts with a preliminary step preferred to as `dump`. During this step, the Hamiltonian and the electron-phonon coupling matrix elements in real space are computed and written to file, to be used in any subsequent calculation. This step is performed only once. The input file is the following:

```
1 &control
2     dump_gR=.true.,
3     prefix='MoS2',
4     elphmat_dir="./mat_elem/"
5 /
6 &electrons
7 /
8 &phonons
9     nq1=8,
10    nq2=8,
11    nq3=1,
12 /
```

Notice, in particular, the following parameters:

- `dump_gR` in the namelist `control` tell the program to save the auxiliary file containing the Hamiltonian and the electron-phonon coupling matrix elements in real space. Since we are not calculating any property of the system the namelist `electron` and `phonons` are essentially empty. Only `nq1,nq2,nq3` have to be supplied in order to specify the q-points mesh where the input electron-phonon coupling matrix elements were computed (in this case, a 8x8x1 q-grid).

Note

In order to keep everything tidy you can use keep the el-ph matrix elements in a separate folder and use the variable `elphmat_dir` in the control namelist:

$\mathcal{E}control \rightarrow elphmat_dir = \text{"path_to_folder"}$

Run this preliminary calculation using:

```
1 mpirun -n <NPROC> {$path_to_epiq}/bin/epiq.x -inp dump.in > dump.out
```

After the dump has ended, some output files have been produced.

- The output file is binary and named `G_and_H.bin` contains the Hamiltonian and the electron-phonon coupling matrix elements in the Wannier representation. If, however, `ascii_G_and_H=.true.` is added in the `&control` namelist then the produced output file is readable and is named `G_and_H.asc`.
- `.dat` files containing the real space localization of the Hamiltonian and the electron-phonon coupling matrix elements.

8.4.2 Check real space localization

If the Wannier transformation is well converged, the matrix elements are optimally localized in real space. Always check their localization.

Test:

Using the two-columns files:

$$\text{"MoS2_gw_R_ph.mu*.dat.pe_1"} \quad |R| \quad \sum_{m,n} |g_{m,n}^\nu(0, \mathbf{R})|^2$$

$$\text{"MoS2_gw_R_el.mu*.dat.pe_1"} \quad |r| \quad \sum_{m,n} |g_{m,n}^\nu(\mathbf{r}, 0)|^2$$

plot the averaged modulus of the electron-phonon matrix elements as a function of the distance in real space $|R|$. Are they localized?

8.5 Exercise phase: calculation of electron-phonon coupling related properties for doped monolayer MoS₂

The phonon-electron linewidth $\gamma_{\mathbf{q},\nu}$ is a central quantity in conventional superconductivity theory. In the double delta (Allen) form is defined by the following equation:

$$\gamma_{\mathbf{q},\nu} = \frac{4\pi\omega_{\mathbf{q},\nu}}{N_k} \sum_{m,n} \sum_{\mathbf{k}} |g_{m,n}^{\nu}(\mathbf{k}, \mathbf{q})|^2 \delta(\epsilon_{\mathbf{k}+\mathbf{q},m} - \epsilon_F) \delta(\epsilon_{\mathbf{k},n} - \epsilon_F)$$

where the electron-phonon coupling is defined from the deformation potential as:

$$g_{m,n}^{\nu}(\mathbf{k}, \mathbf{q}) = \sum_s \mathbf{e}_{\mathbf{q},\nu}^s \cdot \mathbf{d}_{m,n}^s(\mathbf{k}, \mathbf{q}) / \sqrt{2M_s\omega_{\mathbf{q},\nu}}$$

Consider the following input file for the phonon-electron linewidth calculation γ at the M-point of the Brillouin zone. The input parameters are explained in detail in the [EPIq manual](#). Here is the input file:

```

1 &control
2   prefix='MoS2',
3   calculation='ph_linewidth',
4   read_dumped_gr=.true.,
5   dump_gR=.false.,
6   elphmat_dir="./mat_elem/"
7   out2json=.true.
8 /
9
10 &electrons
11   ngauss=0,
12   sigma_min=0.01,
13   sigma_max=0.05
14   nsigma=5,
15 /
16
17 &phonons
18   use_alternative_dyn=.true.
19   prefix_alt_dyn='./dyn_mat/dynq'
20   Fourier_interp_dyn=.true.,
21   nq1=8,nq2=8,nq3=1,
22 /
23
24 k-points
25 automatic
26 4 4 1 0 0 0
27
28 q-points
29 crystal
30 1
31 0.5 0 0 1 ! M

```

The linewidth calculation is then started by:

```

1 mpirun -n <NPROC> {$path_to_epiq}/bin/epiq.x -inp lw.in > lw.out

```

Note that this calculation is done within the harmonic approximation, as we are using the dynamical matrices indicated by the variable `prefix_alt_dyn='./dyn_mat/dynq'`.

Exercise 1:

Perform a convergence study of the linewidth at $\mathbf{M}$ as function of the smearing and the k-mesh density. What is the minimum temperature at which the linewidth of the eighth mode is to be considered at convergence with a k-mesh of 8x8x1 ? And of 12x12x1? Which mode shows larger smearing dependence?

Inclusion of anharmonicity

Now, we want to observe what changes with the inclusion of **anharmonic effects**. To this aim, we need to correctly specify the prefix of the Free-energy Hessian matrices calculated within the SSCHA using `prefix_alt_dyn='./dyn_mat/MoS2.Hessian.dyn'`.

Exercise 2:

Compute the linewidth at $\mathbf{q} = \mathbf{M}$ using anharmonic dynamical matrix computed using SSCHA. Why does it seem like the first and the second mode are exchanged with respect to the harmonic dynamical matrices? What phonon mode(s) shows largest anharmonic correction?

More than one q-point can be specified in the phonon linewidth input file. For example:

```
1 crystal
2 3
3 0.001 0 0 1
4 0.05 0 0 1
5 0.10 0 0 1
```

A plottable file can then be obtained after the phonon linewidth calculation using the `linewidth_path.x` post-processing tool. Here is an example input file:

```
1 &input_lambda
2   prefix='MoS2'
3   lkp_sequential=.true.
4   sigma_min=0.01,
5   sigma_max=0.02,
6   nsigma=2,
7   chosen_sigma=0.01
8 &end
9 3.159998 0.000000 0.000000
10 -1.579999 2.736639 0.000000
11 0.000000 0.000000 19.141895
12 crystal
13 11
14 0.001 0 0 1
15 0.05 0 0 1
16 0.10 0 0 1
17 ...
18 ...
19 0.50 0 0 1
```

Notice the parameter `chosen_sigma`, which specifies what smearing will be used to produce the plottable file, and the lattice parameters at the end of the namelist. The post-processing is executed as follows:

```
1 {$path_to_epiq}/bin/linewidth_path.x < path.in > path.out
```

You can then use the following gnuplot script plots the q-resolved linewidth for the acoustic modes:

```
1 set ylabel '{/Symbol w}(meV)'
2 set xlabel 'Gamma - M'
3 set style fill transparent solid 0.25
4 pl for [i=0:9] 'MoS2_lw_path.d' every 9::i u 1:2 w l lt rgb 'black' title ''
5 repl for [i=0:9] 'MoS2_lw_path.d' every 9::i u ($1):($2-$3/2):($2+$3/2)\
6 w filledc lt rgb 'red' title ''
```

Exercise3:

Try to produce two plots of the phonon dispersion along the $\Gamma - \text{M}$ high-symmetry line in the BZ, one employing the harmonic matrices and one with the anharmonic ones. Do you observe any differences?

8.6 Explanation and details: Phonon linewidth calculation

Let's start again from the example file we considered for the calculation for phonon of momentum $\mathbf{q} = \text{M}$ for two values of the electronic smearing.

```
1 &control
2   prefix='MoS2',
3   calculation='ph_linewidth',
4   read_dumped_gr=.true.,
5   dump_gR=.false.,
6   elphmat_dir="./mat_elem/"
7   out2json=.true.
8 /
9
10 &electrons
11   ngauss=0,
12   sigma_min=0.01,
13   sigma_max=0.05
14   nsigma=5,
15 /
16
17 &phonons
18   use_alternative_dyn=.true.
19   prefix_alt_dyn='./dyn_mat/dynq'
20   Fourier_interp_dyn=.true.,
21   nq1=8,nq2=8,nq3=1,
22 /
23
24 k-points
25 automatic
26 4 4 1 0 0 0
27
28 q-points
29 crystal
30 1
31 0.5 0 0 1 ! M
```

Parameters

- The linewidth calculation is selected by setting the `calculation` parameter equal to `'ph_linewidth'` in the `&control` namelist.
- In the namelist `control`, `read_dumped_gr`, which is set to `.true.`, indicating that electron-phonon coupling matrix elements can be read from `G_and_H.bin`)
- In the namelist `electrons`, `sigma_min`, `sigma_max`, `ngauss` and `nsigma` specify maximum, minimum, type and number of electronic smearing values to use. `efermi` and `ef_from_input` specify the initial guess for the Fermi level (the Fermi level calculated by Quantum ESPRESSO is usually a good guess) and whether the Fermi level should be re-calculated by `epiq` (`ef_from_input` equal to `.false.`) or set from input (`ef_from_input` equal to `.true.`). The variable `thr_compute_k` is used to restrict the calculation only to k-points possessing at least one eigenvalue in the specified energy region near the Fermi level.
- In the namelist `phonons`, `Fourier_interp_dyn` equal to `.true.` asks to interpolate the dynamical matrices for the q-points that do not belong to the Wannier grid. Alternatively, *EPIq*

gives the opportunity to read eigenvalues and eigenvectors produced by `matdyn.x` of the Quantum ESPRESSO package (`matdyn.eig` file), putting `Fourier_interp_dyn=.false.` and `read_modes=.true.` in input, or even to directly read dynamical matrices from a `matdyn.dyn` file, putting `Fourier_interp_dyn=.false.` and `read_modes=.false.`

Output files

If the `out2json` flag is set to `.true.`, the file `MoS2_lambda.json` will be produced. It can be automatically parsed using python as in the following lines where the variable `q_pts` is a “dict” whose entries are the results of the calculation for each q-point. To plot the results, first activate the conda environment with `conda activate sscha`.

```
1 import json
2 ff = './MoS2_lambda.json'
3 with open(ff,'r') as f:
4     q_pts = json.load(f)
5
6 first_q = q_pts["1"]
7
8 print("Fraction coordinate of the q point:", first_q["xq_frac"])
9 print("Electronic temperatures used:", first_q["T"])
10 print("Results for the first mode:", first_q["1"])
11 print("Frequency of the second mode in meV:", first_q["2"]["freq"])
```

Here, a simple python script to plot the linewidth esteemed with the Allen formula:

```
1 import matplotlib.pyplot as plt
2 import numpy as np
3 for q in list(q_pts.values())[:]:
4     for mod in range(1,10):
5         plt.plot( q["T"],q[f'"{mod}"']["gamma_allen"],label=r"$\omega_{"+f'"{mod}"+"}={q[f'"{mod}"']["freq"]:.0f} (meV)",linestyle='--' )
6     plt.xlabel('T (eV)')
7     plt.ylabel(r'$\gamma(T)$ (meV)')
8     plt.legend(title=f"q={ np.round(np.array(q['xq_frac']),2) }")
9     plt.show()
```

Remember to deactivate the environment when running `epiq`. The other output file, `MoS2_lambda.d`, contains all the properties calculated by `EPIq`. The way this file is formatted is specified in output file, `lw.out`. Notice in particular that the first column contains the electronic smearing, while the second column contains the Allen linewidth.

Dispersion along a line

Now we want to perform the calculation of phonon linewidth along a certain crystalline direction and produce a plot like this one:

where the thickness of the lines is proportional to the calculated phonon linewidth. In order to do this, we repeat the phonon linewidth calculation, this time considering the whole Γ -M path:

```
1 &control
2     dump_gR=.false.,
3     read_dumped_gr=.true.,
4     prefix='MoS2',
5     calculation='ph_linewidth',
6     elphmat_dir="./mat_elem/"
7 &end
8 &electrons
9     ngauss=0,
```

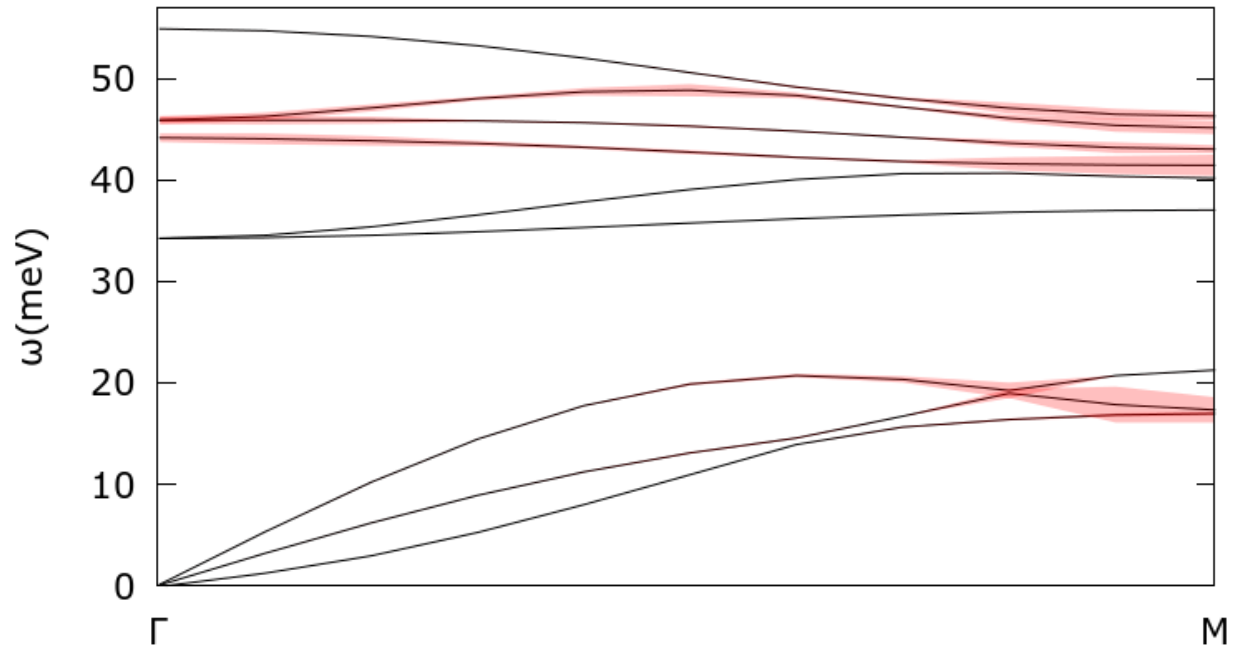



Figure 8.6: wannier

```

10     sigma_min=0.01,
11     sigma_max=0.02
12     nsigma=2,
13 &end
14 &phonons
15     use_alternative_dyn=.true.
16     prefix_alt_dyn='./dyn_mat/MoS2.Hessian.dyn'
17     Fourier_interp_dyn=.true.,
18     nq1=8,nq2=8,nq3=1,
19 &end
20 k-points
21 automatic
22 8 8 1 0 0 0
23 q-points
24 crystal
25 11
26 0.001 0 0 1
27 0.05 0 0 1
28 0.10 0 0 1
29 ...
30 ...
31 0.50 0 0 1

```

Once the linewidth calculation has finished, we can obtain a plottable file using the `linewidth_path.x` post-processing tool. Here is an example of input file:

```

1 &input_lambda
2     prefix='MoS2'
3     lkp_sequential=.true.
4     sigma_min=0.01,
5     sigma_max=0.02,
6     nsigma=2,

```

```

7   chosen_sigma=0.01
8   &end
9   3.159998    0.000000    0.000000
10  -1.579999    2.736639    0.000000
11   0.000000    0.000000    19.141895
12  crystal
13  11
14  0.001 0 0 1
15  0.05 0 0 1
16  0.10 0 0 1
17  ...
18  ...
19  0.50 0 0 1

```

Notice the parameter `chosen_sigma`, which specifies what smearing will be used to produce the plottable file, and the lattice parameters at the end of the namelist. The post-processing is executed as follows:

```

1  {$path_to_epiq}/bin/linewidth_path.x < path.in > path.out

```

8.7 Advanced calculation: superconducting properties of doped MoS₂ using SSCHA Hessian matrices

Having access to phonon linewidths and phonon frequencies allow us to estimate the superconducting critical temperature through the Allen-Dynes formula for T_c :

$$T_c = \frac{f_1 f_2 \omega_{ln}}{1.20} \exp \left[\frac{-1.04(1 + \lambda)}{\lambda - \mu^*(1 + 0.62\lambda)} \right]$$

where the electron-phonon coupling parameter λ is defined as:

$$\lambda = 2 \int \frac{\alpha^2 F(\omega)}{\omega} d\omega,$$

and the Eliashberg function is defined as

$$\begin{aligned} \alpha^2 F(\omega) &= \frac{1}{N(E_F)} \sum_{\mathbf{k}q\nu} \sum_{nm} |g_{\mathbf{k}+\mathbf{q},\mathbf{k}}^{v,mn}|^2 \times \delta(\omega - \omega_{\mathbf{q}v}) \delta(\epsilon_{\mathbf{k}+\mathbf{q}}^m - \epsilon_F) \delta(\epsilon_{\mathbf{k}}^n - \epsilon_F) \\ &= \frac{1}{4\pi N(\varepsilon_F)} \sum_{\mathbf{q}v} \frac{\gamma_{\mathbf{q}v}}{\omega_{\mathbf{q}v}} \delta(\omega - \omega_{\mathbf{q}v}), \end{aligned}$$

while the logarithmic average frequency is: $\omega_{ln} = \exp \left[\frac{2}{\lambda} \int_0^\infty \frac{\alpha^2 F(\omega)}{\omega} \ln(\omega) d\omega \right]$

To calculate the q-sum appearing in the Eliashberg function, we would like to calculate the linewidths on a grid. In order to do so, we only have to modify the q-points part of the linewidth input file as follows:

```

1  &control
2    dump_gR=.false.,
3    read_dumped_gr=.true.,
4    prefix='MoS2',
5    calculation='ph_linewidth',
6    elphmat_dir="./mat_elem/"
7  &end

```

```

8 &electrons
9   ngauss=0,
10  sigma_min=0.01,
11  sigma_max=0.02
12  nsigma=2,
13 &end
14 &phonons
15   use_alternative_dyn=.true.
16   prefix_alt_dyn='./dyn_mat/dynq'
17   Fourier_interp_dyn=.true.,
18   nq1=8,nq2=8,nq3=1,
19 &end
20 k-points
21 automatic
22 12 12 1 0 0 0
23 q-points
24 crystal
25 automatic
26 12 12 1 0 0 0

```

Finally, the superconducting T_c can be calculate with the `average_lambda.x` post processing with the following input file:

```

1 &input_lambda
2 prefix='MoS2'
3 n_mustar=15
4 lkp_sequential=.true.
5 mu_min=0.01
6 mu_max=0.15
7 sigma_min=0.01,
8 sigma_max=0.02,
9 nsigma=2,
10 &end
11 AUTOMATIC
12 12 12 1 0 0 0

```

besides the automatic grid in input (same as the q-points grid in the linewidth calculation), this input only contains σ (smearing employed in the double delta q summation) and μ^* ranges to be employed in the T_c calculation. Then simply run

```

1 { $path_to_epiq }/bin/average_lambda.x <input_average_lambda.in

```

This will produce an output named `MoS2_average_lambda.d` , containing relevant information for superconductivity as a function of the smearing parameter σ and μ^* .

Exercise:

Evaluate the superconducting critical temperature for doped MoS_2 , first employing harmonic dynamical matrices and then the one obtained from the SSCHA minimization. Does the predicted superconducting critical temperature change?

Employ a 12x12x1 automatic k-grid and q-grid in the phonon linewidth calculation as a test. You can then study the convergence as a function of the k- and q- grid dimension in the linewidth calculation. You should see that the predicted critical temperature is lower when the anharmonic Hessian matrices are employed.

General remarks:

A complete calculation of anharmonic electron phonon coupling related properties within SSCHA+EPIq requires the following steps:

1. [The SSCHA code](#) → First, compute the free energy Hessian within the stochastic self-consistent harmonic approximation (SSCHA).
2. [Quantum ESPRESSO code](#) → Then, compute electron-phonon coupling matrix elements following the instructions reported in the EPIq site <https://the-epiq-team.gitlab.io/epiq-site/docs/tutorials/step1/>.
3. [Wannier90 code](#) → Identify the unitary transformation connecting the Bloch and the maximally-smooth gauge (required to interpolate the electron-phonon coupling matrix elements in the Wannier basis).
4. [EPIq code](#) → Perform the electron-phonon coupling interpolation in the Wannier basis and calculate physical properties including the anharmonic correction from SSCHA.

All these open-source software can be downloaded following the instruction in each website.

If you want to know more about the full procedure, please take a look at the tutorials on the [EPIq site](#).